ECONOMIC INTELLIGENCE SERIES

# U.S. Metro Economic Health Report

50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas

Percentile-Based Composite Scoring · 8 Metrics · BLS & FRED Data
85% Employment / 15% Housing · October 2026

## TOP PERFORMERS

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| #1 | A | Salt Lake City | 71.8 |
| #2 | A | Raleigh | 70.8 |
| #3 | A | St. Louis | 69.2 |
| #4 | A | Las Vegas | 69.0 |
| #5 | A | Austin | 68.1 |
| #6 | A- | Charlotte | 67.9 |
| #7 | A- | Cincinnati | 67.1 |

## MARKETS UNDER PRESSURE

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| #50 | D | Detroit | 19.1 |
| #49 | D | Chicago | 26.5 |
| #48 | D | Louisville | 28.8 |
| #47 | D | Grand Rapids | 29.7 |
| #46 | C- | Jacksonville | 31.6 |
| #45 | C- | Indianapolis | 32.3 |
| #44 | C- | Fresno | 35.0 |

## GRADE DISTRIBUTION

| | |
|---|---|
| A+ / A / A- | 9 cities |
| B+ / B / B- | 15 cities |
| C+ / C / C- | 22 cities |
| D | 4 cities |

Data sources: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) · Federal Reserve Economic Data (FRED)
Unemployment, CLF Growth, Earnings, Employment, Weekly Hours sourced from BLS LAUS / SAE.
Building Permits from Census Bureau via FRED. Days on Market from Realtor.com / FRED.

Scoring methodology: percentile ranking across all 50 metros.
Full methodology: SCORING_README.md
Pipeline runs weekly via GitHub Actions.

# Full Rankings

All 50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas · Sorted by composite score · October 2026

| # | METRO | GRADE | SCORE | UNEMP. | WAGE YOY | EMP. YOY | CLF YOY | DOM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | **Salt Lake City**<br>Salt Lake City-Murray | A | 71.8 | 3.7% | +4.5% | +2.5% | +0.3% | 58 days |
| 2 | **Raleigh**<br>Raleigh-Cary | A | 70.8 | 3.1% | +3.2% | +2.2% | -1.6% | 59 days |
| 3 | **St. Louis**<br>St. Louis | A | 69.2 | 3.9% | +3.5% | +0.7% | -1.3% | 50 days |
| 4 | **Las Vegas**<br>Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas | A | 69.0 | 4.8% | +4.2% | +1.5% | -0.2% | 58 days |
| 5 | **Austin**<br>Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos | A | 68.1 | 3.9% | +5.1% | +1.2% | +0.6% | 80 days |
| 6 | **Charlotte**<br>Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia | A- | 67.9 | 3.7% | +4.2% | +1.5% | -1.5% | 64 days |
| 7 | **Cincinnati**<br>Cincinnati | A- | 67.1 | 3.6% | +8.1% | +0.3% | -1.4% | 44 days |
| 8 | **Hartford**<br>Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford | A- | 67.1 | 2.7% | +5.3% | +1.9% | +2.8% | 35 days |
| 9 | **Philadelphia**<br>Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington | A- | 66.1 | 4.4% | +2.1% | +0.8% | +1.2% | 49 days |
| 10 | **Kansas City**<br>Kansas City | B+ | 61.4 | 3.9% | +7.3% | +0.7% | -2.1% | 50 days |
| 11 | **Dallas**<br>Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington | B+ | 61.3 | 4.4% | +4.0% | +1.0% | +0.6% | 62 days |
| 12 | **Baltimore**<br>Baltimore-Columbia-Towson | B+ | 60.5 | 3.9% | +6.0% | -0.5% | -0.5% | 46 days |
| 13 | **Orlando**<br>Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford | B+ | 60.2 | 4.6% | +6.1% | +0.8% | +0.4% | 77 days |
| 14 | **Pittsburgh**<br>Pittsburgh | B | 58.4 | 3.9% | +3.3% | -0.1% | +1.1% | 54 days |
| 15 | **Seattle**<br>Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue | B | 55.3 | 4.8% | +5.4% | +0.9% | -0.5% | 51 days |
| 16 | **Tampa**<br>Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater | B- | 54.8 | 4.7% | +5.1% | +0.9% | +0.3% | 76 days |
| 17 | **Miami**<br>Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach | B- | 54.1 | 3.7% | +7.7% | +0.3% | +0.4% | 85 days |
| 18 | **Los Angeles**<br>Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim | B- | 53.9 | 4.8% | +3.4% | +1.8% | -1.9% | 55 days |
| 19 | **Columbus**<br>Columbus | B- | 52.8 | 3.3% | +4.2% | +0.1% | -2.2% | 48 days |
| 20 | **Atlanta**<br>Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell | B- | 51.8 | 3.4% | +3.1% | -0.5% | +1.2% | 60 days |
| 21 | **San Antonio**<br>San Antonio-New Braunfels | B- | 51.1 | 4.5% | +3.7% | +0.5% | +0.2% | 71 days |
| 22 | **Nashville**<br>Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin | B- | 51.1 | 3.2% | +3.9% | +0.7% | -1.3% | 62 days |
| 23 | **Cleveland**<br>Cleveland | B- | 50.8 | 3.4% | +0.9% | +0.6% | +1.8% | 55 days |
| 24 | **Washington DC**<br>Washington-Arlington-Alexandria | B- | 50.3 | 3.8% | +5.8% | -2.0% | -3.6% | 43 days |

| # | METRO | GRADE | SCORE | UNEMP. | WAGE YOY | EMP. YOY | CLF YOY | DOM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 25 | **San Francisco**<br>San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont | C+ | 49.7 | 4.6% | +5.8% | +0.6% | -2.3% | 37 days |
| 26 | **Birmingham**<br>Birmingham | C+ | 49.1 | 3.4% | +0.0% | +0.9% | -1.3% | 61 days |
| 27 | **Houston**<br>Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands | C+ | 48.5 | 5.0% | +1.2% | +1.3% | +0.6% | 55 days |
| 28 | **Oklahoma City**<br>Oklahoma City | C+ | 46.7 | 3.9% | +4.2% | +0.7% | -1.6% | 57 days |
| 29 | **Boston**<br>Boston-Cambridge-Newton | C+ | 45.0 | 3.9% | +2.9% | -0.1% | +2.9% | 43 days |
| 30 | **Providence**<br>Providence-Warwick | C+ | 44.8 | 4.3% | +3.1% | +0.6% | +1.7% | 39 days |
| 31 | **Phoenix**<br>Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler | C+ | 44.6 | 4.9% | +3.3% | +0.9% | -2.9% | 62 days |
| 32 | **Portland**<br>Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro | C+ | 44.6 | 4.9% | +5.7% | -1.5% | +0.1% | 66 days |
| 33 | **San Jose**<br>San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara | C | 42.5 | 4.3% | -0.8% | +1.6% | -1.1% | 35 days |
| 34 | **Virginia Beach**<br>Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk | C | 41.2 | 3.7% | +5.5% | -0.6% | -2.6% | 44 days |
| 35 | **New York**<br>New York Newark-Jersey City | C | 39.7 | 4.7% | +1.9% | +0.5% | -0.1% | 56 days |
| 36 | **Minneapolis**<br>Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington | C | 39.7 | 4.7% | +0.3% | +1.4% | -1.8% | 42 days |
| 37 | **Sacramento**<br>Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom | C | 38.9 | 5.2% | +2.0% | +0.8% | -1.5% | 51 days |
| 38 | **San Diego**<br>San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad | C | 38.8 | 4.9% | +7.5% | +0.7% | -2.1% | 46 days |
| 39 | **Milwaukee**<br>Milwaukee-Waukesha | C | 38.1 | 3.8% | +0.5% | -0.2% | +1.6% | 37 days |
| 40 | **Denver**<br>Denver-Aurora-Centennial | C- | 36.6 | 4.6% | +2.1% | +0.1% | -3.0% | 58 days |
| 41 | **Riverside**<br>Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario | C- | 35.5 | 5.9% | +5.5% | +0.8% | -1.7% | 64 days |
| 42 | **Richmond**<br>Richmond | C- | 35.3 | 3.6% | +2.4% | -0.8% | -2.6% | 44 days |
| 43 | **Memphis**<br>Memphis | C- | 35.3 | 4.6% | +4.5% | -0.5% | -2.8% | 72 days |
| 44 | **Fresno**<br>Fresno | C- | 35.0 | 7.8% | +4.5% | +0.8% | -1.3% | 58 days |
| 45 | **Indianapolis**<br>Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood | C- | 32.3 | 3.3% | +0.6% | -1.1% | -1.9% | 53 days |
| 46 | **Jacksonville**<br>Jacksonville | C- | 31.6 | 4.8% | +1.3% | +0.1% | -0.6% | 66 days |
| 47 | **Grand Rapids**<br>Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood | D | 29.7 | 4.2% | +1.4% | +0.7% | -7.2% | 42 days |
| 48 | **Louisville**<br>Louisville-Jefferson County | D | 28.8 | 4.1% | +1.7% | -0.1% | -0.8% | 45 days |
| 49 | **Chicago**<br>Chicago-Naperville-Elgin | D | 26.5 | 5.2% | +3.3% | +0.2% | -3.1% | 36 days |
| 50 | **Detroit**<br>Detroit-Warren-Dearborn | D | 19.1 | 5.7% | +1.5% | -0.2% | -1.8% | 43 days |

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #1 OF 50

# Salt Lake City

Salt Lake City-Murray

**A**

VERY GOOD

71.8th percentile

Rank 1 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT **3.7%** of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY **+4.5%** avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+2.5%** nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY **+0.3%** civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS **+28.2%** residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET **58 days** median, 0.0% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**GROWING**

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 71.8th percentile among 50 US metros, with a strong labor demand and a deep professional talent pool being the two metrics that most define its current economic character, scoring in the 90th percentile for both labor demand composite and office/professional worker share. The labor demand composite score of 7.39, driven by a 2.49% employment growth rate and a -0.398% weekly hours deviation, signals genuine demand expansion. This combination of metrics suggests a city with a strong and growing economy.

### Labor Demand

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area has seen a 2.49% employment growth rate year-over-year, combined with a -0.398% deviation in weekly hours from its own 12-month baseline, indicating genuine demand expansion. This signals that the city is adding jobs and that the existing workforce is not being overburdened, as hours are not significantly above trend. The labor demand composite score of 7.39 further reinforces this interpretation, placing the city in the top tier.

### Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Salt Lake City-Murray stands at 3.70%, ranking in the 74th percentile, which indicates a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market implies that wage pressure is likely to be upward.

### Wage Growth

The city has experienced a 4.49% year-over-year wage growth, ranking in the 64th percentile, which is above average but not exceptionally high. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a manageable rate, and worker purchasing power is increasing. However, it may not be sufficient to outpace cost of living increases significantly.

### Cost of Living

Salt Lake City-Murray has a cost of living score that places it in the 40th percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of $262/sqft to $39.26/hr, or 6.67. This indicates that the city is less affordable than many of its peers, as the cost of living is relatively high compared to wages. The slight increase in PSF year-over-year further suggests that affordability is not improving. This could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

### Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Salt Lake City-Murray has grown by 0.35% year-over-year, ranking in the 72nd percentile, indicating a slow but positive expansion of the workforce supply. This slow growth suggests that while hiring capacity is not severely constrained, it may not be

as robust as in cities with higher labor force growth rates.

**Building Permits**

The city has seen a 28.20% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, placing it in the 84th percentile. This significant rise in permits signals that housing supply is expected to expand, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. This trend is positive for businesses looking to relocate or expand, as it suggests a more favorable future housing market.

**Days on Market**

The median days on market for homes in Salt Lake City-Murray is 58 days, with a 0% year-over-year change, ranking in the 36th percentile. This relatively fast market means that homes are selling quickly, which can make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the stable year-over-year trend suggests that the market is not becoming significantly more competitive.

**Office Economy**

With an office/professional worker share composite score of 4.31, ranking in the 92nd percentile, Salt Lake City-Murray has a very deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. This makes the city highly suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions, but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for certain types of businesses. However, the relatively high cost of living and tight labor market, which may lead to wage pressure, are significant factors that decision-makers should consider when evaluating this location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #2 OF 50

# Raleigh

Raleigh-Cary

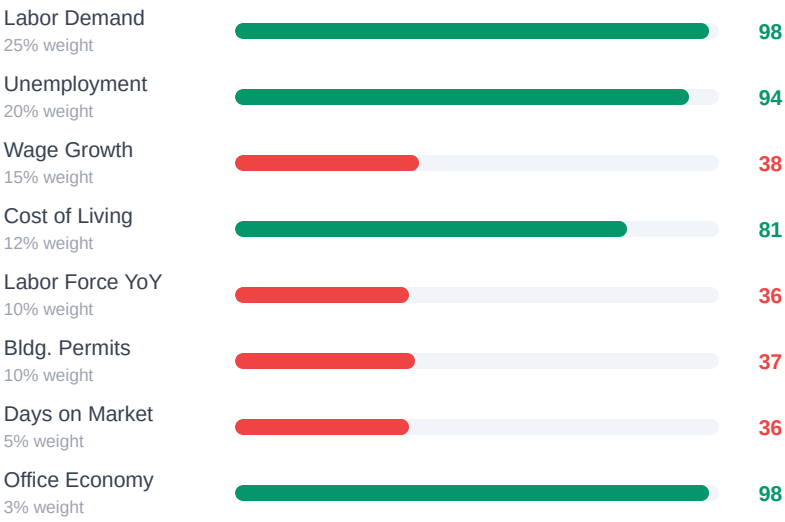
**A**

VERY GOOD

70.8th percentile

Rank 2 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT **3.1%** of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY **+3.2%** avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+2.2%** nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY **-1.6%** civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS **-5.7%** residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET **59 days** median, 0.0% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**STRONG**

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Raleigh-Cary metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 70.8th percentile among 50 US metros, with a strong labor demand and low unemployment rate defining its current economic character, at 98th and 94th percentiles, respectively. The labor demand composite score of 8.63, driven by a 2.23% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.207% deviation in weekly hours above trend, signals a genuine demand expansion. This combination of metrics suggests a thriving job market.

### Labor Demand

The Raleigh-Cary metro area has seen a 2.23% year-over-year employment growth rate, coupled with a 1.207% deviation in weekly hours above trend, indicating a strong labor demand. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, where jobs are being added and hours are increasing, suggesting a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 8.63 further reinforces this notion, placing the city in the top tier.

### Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Raleigh-Cary stands at 3.10%, which is in the top tier, indicating a tight labor market. This low unemployment rate implies that it may be challenging for businesses to hire, as the pool of available workers is limited, and wage pressure may be higher. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

### Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Raleigh-Cary is 3.16%, which is below average, ranking in the 38th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, albeit not as rapidly as in other cities. This may impact businesses' decisions on staffing and compensation.

### Cost of Living

Raleigh-Cary has a cost of living score that places it in the 81st percentile, with a PSF of $213/sqft and average hourly earnings of $38.60/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.52. The fact that PSF is decreasing by 3.2% year-over-year makes the city more affordable. This affordability advantage can be a significant talent attraction factor, as workers may not require wage premiums to maintain their standard of living.

### Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Raleigh-Cary has contracted by 1.63% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This negative growth rate implies that the supply of workers is decreasing, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion. Companies may need to adapt their recruitment strategies to attract workers from other areas.

**Building Permits**

The number of residential building permits in Raleigh-Cary has decreased by 5.68% year-over-year, suggesting that housing supply is tightening. This decline in building permits may lead to a supply squeeze, potentially impacting future affordability and workforce accommodation. As a result, businesses may face challenges in attracting and retaining workers due to limited housing options.

**Days on Market**

The median days on market for homes in Raleigh-Cary is 59 days, with no year-over-year change. This relatively fast pace indicates a competitive market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the stable days on market suggests that the market is not overheating, and workers may still find suitable housing options.

**Office Economy**

Raleigh-Cary has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking in the 98th percentile. This suggests that the city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized workers. However, it may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Raleigh-Cary metro area offers businesses a strong labor market, low unemployment, and an affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand or relocate. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor pool, which may pose challenges for hiring and business growth, and the tightening housing supply, which could impact workforce accommodation and affordability.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #3 OF 50

# St. Louis

St. Louis

**A**

VERY GOOD

69.2th percentile

Rank 3 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT **3.9%** of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY **+3.5%** avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.7%** nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY **-1.3%** civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS **+18.1%** residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET **50 days** median, +8.7% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**STRONG**

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

St. Louis has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 69.2th percentile among 50 US metros, with a strong labor demand and highly affordable cost of living being the two metrics that most define its current economic character, scoring 78th and 98th percentiles respectively. The city's labor demand composite score of 6.44 and cost of living ratio of 4.28, with PSF at $163/sqft and hourly earnings at $38.11, signal a favorable business environment. With these metrics, St. Louis presents a unique blend of economic growth and affordability.

### Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in St. Louis is +0.68% year-over-year, combined with a +1.193% deviation in weekly hours from its own 12-month baseline, indicating genuine demand expansion as both jobs and hours worked are increasing. This combination signals a strong labor market where businesses are adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 6.44 further reinforces this positive outlook.

### Unemployment

The unemployment rate in St. Louis stands at 3.90%, which is above average, ranking in the 72nd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market with some slack. For businesses trying to hire in this market, the implication is that while it may be slightly challenging to find talent, it is not excessively competitive, and wage pressure, although present, is manageable. This balance suggests a stable environment for recruitment.

### Wage Growth

St. Louis experiences a year-over-year wage growth of +3.51%, placing it near the median at the 48th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing but at a pace that does not overly strain budgets. For workers, this translates into modestly increasing purchasing power, supporting local consumer demand without excessively inflating costs for businesses.

### Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 4.28, where PSF is $163/sqft and hourly earnings are $38.11, and considering the PSF has decreased by -1.8% year-over-year, St. Louis ranks in the 98th percentile for affordability. This high ranking means the city is very affordable relative to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without the need for significant wage premiums to offset living costs. The decreasing PSF relative to wages is a key driver of this affordability.

### Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in St. Louis has contracted by -1.33% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing, which could challenge businesses looking to expand their workforce in the area. Managing recruitment and retention strategies will be crucial in this environment.

**Building Permits**

St. Louis has seen an increase of +18.07% in residential building permits year-over-year, signaling an expansion in housing supply. This growth in permits suggests that developer confidence is strong, and the future housing supply is expected to improve, which should help maintain or improve affordability and support the attraction and accommodation of the workforce.

**Days on Market**

The median days on market for homes in St. Louis is 50 days, with an increase of +8.7% year-over-year, ranking in the 74th percentile. This indicates a slower market where homes are sitting longer before being sold, making it a more accessible and less competitive environment for workers relocating to the city. The rising DOM suggests a healthy normalization of the housing market.

**Office Economy**

St. Louis has a professional and office worker share that places it in the 51st percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool suited for businesses requiring specialized roles, though it may not be as robust as in cities with a higher concentration of tech, finance, or consulting sectors. This city is best suited for businesses that can thrive in a mixed economy with a balance of industrial, logistics, and professional services, and less suited for those requiring a highly specialized knowledge-economy workforce.

In conclusion, St. Louis offers businesses a unique combination of a strong labor demand, highly affordable cost of living, and a moderately growing economy, making it an attractive location for investment and expansion. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the shrinking labor force, which could pose challenges for hiring and workforce expansion plans, necessitating strategic recruitment and retention initiatives to thrive in this market.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #4 OF 50

# Las Vegas

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas

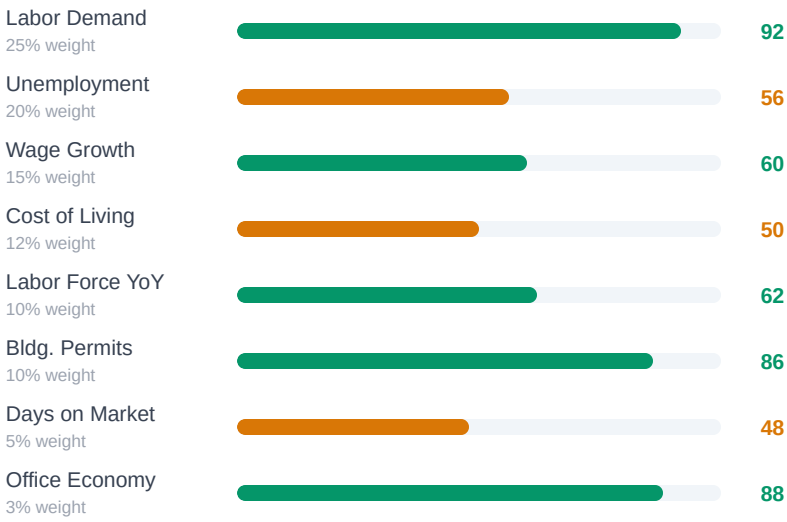
**A**

VERY GOOD

69.0th percentile

Rank 4 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT **4.8%** of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY **+4.2%** avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.5%** nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY **-0.2%** civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS **+28.5%** residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET **58 days** median, +1.8% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**STRONG**

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 69.0th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and office economy. The city's labor demand composite score of 7.44, which combines a 1.46% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.098% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. This, coupled with its top-tier office economy, defines the city's current economic character.

### Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 1.46% and weekly hours deviation of 1.098% above trend indicate a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 7.44, ranking in the 92nd percentile, further reinforces this assessment.

### Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.80% places the city near the median, ranking in the 56th percentile. This rate suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, it also implies that local consumer demand may not be as strong as in areas with lower unemployment rates.

### Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 4.21% is above average, ranking in the 60th percentile. This moderate to fast wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, which can be a challenge for businesses but also indicates good worker purchasing power. As wages grow, workers have more disposable income, potentially benefiting local businesses.

### Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $259/sqft to $33.35/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.77, and a percentile rank of 50th, the city is near the median in terms of affordability. The fact that PSF is falling by 3.0% year-over-year relative to wages is a key driver of its affordability. This means the city offers a relatively neutral environment for talent attraction, neither requiring significant wage premiums to compensate for high costs nor offering a substantial advantage in terms of affordability.

### Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of -0.21% year-over-year, which, despite being a slight contraction, ranks in the 62nd percentile. This slight decline in labor force growth suggests that the supply of workers is not expanding as quickly as in other areas, potentially presenting a structural headwind for hiring in the future.

### Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is +28.53%, ranking in the 86th percentile, indicating a significant expansion in housing supply. This surge in residential building permits signals developer confidence in the market and suggests that future housing supply will increase, potentially improving affordability and accommodating a growing workforce.

**Days on Market**

Homes are currently sitting on the market for 58 days, with a year-over-year increase of 1.8%. This moderate days on market, ranking in the 48th percentile, suggests a relatively balanced market that is neither extremely competitive nor overly accessible for relocating workers. The slight increase in days on market may indicate a healthy normalization of the housing market.

**Office Economy**

The city's office economy, with a composite score of 3.84 and ranking in the 88th percentile, indicates a deep talent pool suited for professional, tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses in these sectors but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and a deep professional talent pool, making it particularly attractive for office and professional services sectors. However, the slight contraction in labor force growth presents a risk that decision-makers should factor in, as it may impact future hiring capacity and require strategic workforce planning.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #5 OF 50

# Austin

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos

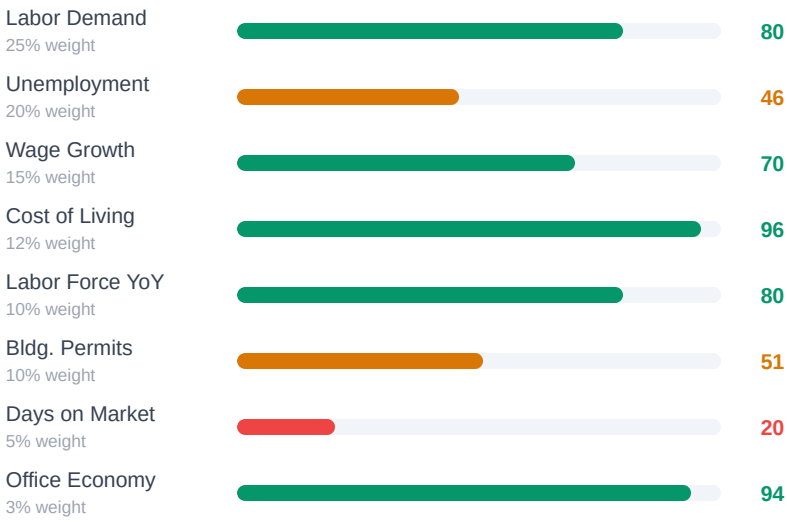
**A**

VERY GOOD

68.1th percentile

Rank 5 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT **3.9%** of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY **+5.1%** avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.2%** nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY **+0.6%** civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS **+2.5%** residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET **80 days** median, +1.3% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**STRONG**

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 68.1th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven significantly by its top-tier labor demand and cost of living metrics, scoring 80th and 96th percentiles respectively. The city's labor demand composite score of 6.59, combining a +1.16% employment growth rate and a +0.667% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, signals a genuine demand expansion. This, coupled with its highly affordable cost of living, makes it an attractive location for businesses.

**Labor Demand**

The employment growth rate of +1.16% and weekly hours deviation of +0.667% from its own trend indicate a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing job growth with hours running above trend, suggesting that businesses are hiring and workers are in high demand. The labor demand composite score of 6.59 further reinforces this, placing it in the top tier.

**Unemployment**

The unemployment rate of 3.90% places the city near the median, ranking in the 46th percentile. This rate suggests that while the market is not overly tight, it does have some slack, making it somewhat easier for businesses to hire compared to cities with lower unemployment rates. However, this also means that local consumer demand might not be as strong as in areas with lower unemployment.

**Wage Growth**

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of +5.08%, the city experiences above-average wage growth, ranking in the 70th percentile. This indicates that labor costs for employers are rising, but it also means that workers have stronger purchasing power. The implication is a trade-off between higher labor costs for businesses and a more affluent local workforce.

**Cost of Living**

The cost of living in Austin, with a PSF of $228/sqft (which has decreased by 8.4% YoY) compared to average hourly earnings of $37.93, results in a ratio of 6.01, ranking it in the 96th percentile for affordability. This high ranking means the city is very affordable relative to its peers, offering a significant talent attraction advantage without the need for wage premiums.

**Labor Force Growth**

The civilian labor force has grown by +0.64% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the city's hiring capacity is not constrained by a shrinking labor pool, providing a favorable environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

**Building Permits**

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +2.50%, ranking near the median at the 51st percentile. This moderate increase in permits suggests that housing supply is slowly expanding, which could improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce over time.

**Days on Market**

Homes in Austin currently sit on the market for a median of 80 days, with a year-over-year increase of +1.3%. This increase, coupled with the absolute level, indicates a market that is becoming slightly less competitive for buyers, which could be beneficial for relocating workers as it suggests a more accessible housing market.

**Office Economy**

With an office and professional worker share composite score of 4.39, ranking in the 94th percentile, Austin has a deep and talented pool of professional workers. This makes the city highly suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less ideal for those primarily involved in industrial or logistics operations.

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, highly affordable cost of living, and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for a variety of industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the potential for rising labor costs due to above-average wage growth, which could impact business profitability and competitiveness over time.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #6 OF 50

# Charlotte

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia

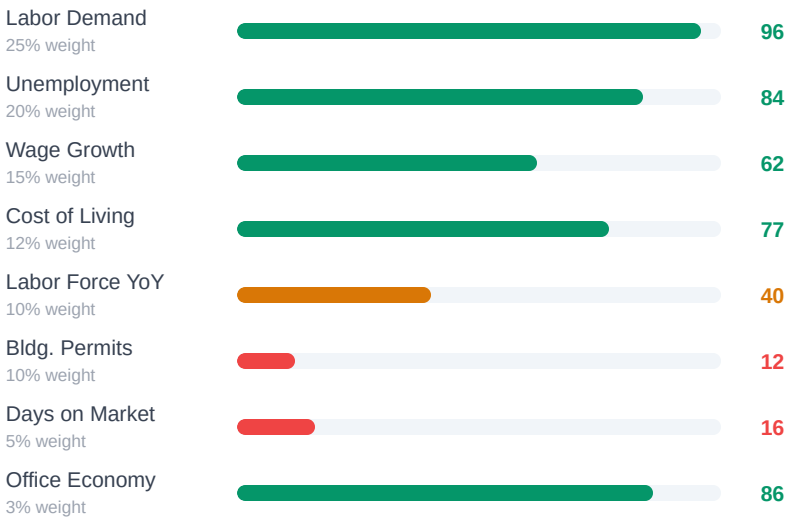
**A-**

GOOD

67.9th percentile

Rank 6 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT<br>**3.7%**<br>of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY<br>**+4.2%**<br>avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH<br>**+1.5%**<br>nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY<br>**-1.5%**<br>civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS<br>**-22.8%**<br>residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET<br>**64 days**<br>median, +10.3% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**STRONG**

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area has earned an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking in the 67.9th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 96th percentile, and its relatively low unemployment rate of 3.70%, ranking in the 84th percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a city with a robust job market and limited labor supply slack.

**Labor Demand**

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area has seen employment growth of +1.54% year-over-year, combined with a +1.361% deviation in weekly hours above its own 12-month trend. This signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth, indicating that the labor market is experiencing an increase in workload without relying on survivor squeeze. The labor demand composite score of 7.82 further reinforces this notion, ranking in the top tier at 96th percentile.

**Unemployment**

The unemployment rate in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia stands at 3.70%, which is relatively low and ranks in the 84th percentile. This indicates a tight labor market with limited slack, making it more challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, companies may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain top talent in this competitive job market.

**Wage Growth**

The year-over-year wage growth in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is +4.22%, ranking in the 62nd percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. At the same time, workers are experiencing an increase in purchasing power, which can have a positive impact on local consumer demand.

**Cost of Living**

With a cost of living ratio of $217/sqft to $38.91/hr, Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia ranks in the 77th percentile in terms of affordability. The fact that PSF is decreasing by -1.4% year-over-year relative to wages makes the city more attractive for talent, as it offers a relatively affordable environment without requiring significant wage premiums. This can be a major advantage for businesses looking to attract and retain employees.

**Labor Force Growth**

The civilian labor force in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia has contracted by -1.49% year-over-year, ranking near the median at 40th percentile. This decline in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may face challenges in finding qualified candidates to fill open positions.

**Building Permits**

The number of residential building permits in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia has decreased by -22.75% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at 12th percentile. This sharp decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

**Days on Market**

The current median days on market in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is 64 days, with a year-over-year increase of +10.3%. This indicates a slower market, ranking in the bottom tier at 16th percentile. For workers relocating to this city, the slower market may make it more accessible to find housing, but it also signals a potential erosion of demand.

**Office Economy**

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share ranking in the top tier at 86th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which rely on a knowledgeable and specialized workforce. In contrast, it may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented economies.

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, a relatively low unemployment rate, and a moderate wage growth environment. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce, potentially offsetting the city's otherwise attractive economic characteristics.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #7 OF 50

# Cincinnati

Cincinnati

**A-**

GOOD

67.1th percentile

Rank 7 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT<br>**3.6%**<br>of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY<br>**+8.1%**<br>avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH<br>**+0.3%**<br>nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY<br>**-1.4%**<br>civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS<br>**-1.8%**<br>residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET<br>**44 days**<br>median, +12.8% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**STRONG**

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cincinnati earns an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking at the 67.1th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 3.60% and strong wage growth of +8.11% year-over-year, indicating a tight labor market with rising labor costs. These metrics suggest that Cincinnati is an attractive location for businesses looking for a skilled workforce, but may face challenges in hiring due to the competitive job market.

### Labor Demand

Cincinnati's employment growth rate is +0.31% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating by +0.000% from its own trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.73, which ranks below average at the 32th percentile. This combination signals a modest expansion of genuine demand, but at a slower pace than many peer cities. The labor market is growing, but not at a rate that would indicate a significant surge in hiring activity.

### Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cincinnati is 3.60%, ranking at the 92th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market with minimal slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for talent, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. With such a low unemployment rate, companies may need to offer competitive salaries and benefits to attract and retain top workers.

### Wage Growth

Wage growth in Cincinnati is +8.11% year-over-year, ranking at the 98th percentile, which is exceptionally strong. This rapid wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs, but can also expect a skilled and affluent workforce with strong consumer demand.

### Cost of Living

Cincinnati has a cost of living score that ranks at the 94th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $190/sqft (decreasing by 1.0% year-over-year) to $36.31/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.23. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The decreasing price-to-salary ratio is a key driver of this affordability, suggesting that the city's housing market is becoming more accessible.

### Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cincinnati is shrinking at a rate of -1.35% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 42th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply implies that hiring capacity may be limited, and businesses may face challenges in finding qualified workers. As the labor force shrinks, companies may need to invest in training and development programs to attract and retain talent.

**Building Permits**

The number of building permits in Cincinnati is decreasing by -1.83% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 47th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation in the future. As the housing market becomes less accessible, businesses may need to consider offering relocation assistance or other incentives to attract workers.

**Days on Market**

The median days on market in Cincinnati is currently 44 days, with a year-over-year increase of +12.8%, ranking at the 92th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, this trend may also suggest a normalization of the housing market, rather than a significant decrease in demand.

**Office Economy**

Cincinnati's professional and office worker share ranks near the median at the 41st percentile, with a composite score of 2.31. This suggests that the city has a moderate-sized talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions, but may not be as deep as in other major metropolitan areas. While Cincinnati is a viable location for knowledge-economy businesses, it may not be the best fit for companies requiring a highly specialized or abundant professional workforce.

In conclusion, Cincinnati offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, strong wage growth, and relatively low cost of living, making it an attractive location for companies looking for a skilled and affluent workforce. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force supply, which may limit hiring capacity and require investments in training and development programs to attract and retain talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #8 OF 50

# Hartford

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford

**A-**

GOOD

67.1th percentile

Rank 8 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT **2.7%** of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY **+5.3%** avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.9%** nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY **+2.8%** civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS **-26.7%** residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET **35 days** median, -2.8% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**STRONG**

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area has earned an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking it at the 67.1th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 86th percentile, and its extremely low unemployment rate of 2.70%, ranking it at the 98th percentile. The combination of these two metrics signals a highly competitive job market with genuine demand expansion.

**Labor Demand**

The employment growth rate in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is +1.88% year-over-year, accompanied by a +0.025% deviation in weekly hours from its own 12-month baseline. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth, indicating that the economy is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours to meet the increased demand. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to expand or establish operations in the area.

**Unemployment**

The unemployment rate in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is 2.70%, which is extremely low and ranks at the 98th percentile. This indicates a very tight labor market with little slack, making it challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain top talent in this competitive market.

**Wage Growth**

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is +5.30%, which is above average and ranks at the 74th percentile. This moderate to fast wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power, which can be beneficial for local businesses that rely on consumer spending.

**Cost of Living**

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford has a cost of living score that ranks at the 25th percentile, with a PSF of $250/sqft and average hourly earnings of $40.19/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.22. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which may make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is rising by 3.7% year-over-year further exacerbates the affordability issue.

**Labor Force Growth**

The civilian labor force in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is growing at a rate of +2.77% year-over-year, which is a top-tier growth rate ranking at the 96th percentile. This expanding labor force supply is a positive sign for businesses, as it indicates a growing pool of potential employees and reduced hiring constraints.

**Building Permits**

The number of residential building permits in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford has decreased by -26.73% year-over-year, which is a bottom-tier performance ranking at the 10th percentile. This sharp decline in building permits signals a potential tightening of the housing supply, which could lead to decreased affordability and increased challenges for businesses looking to attract and retain workers.

**Days on Market**

The current median days on market for homes in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is 35 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -2.8%. This relatively fast pace of home sales indicates a competitive market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find affordable housing options.

**Office Economy**

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford has a professional and office worker share that ranks at the 22nd percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This city is best suited for businesses that do not rely heavily on specialized office or professional workers, such as industrial or logistics companies, but may be less ideal for tech, finance, or consulting firms that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool.

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area offers businesses a highly competitive job market with strong labor demand and low unemployment, but also presents challenges such as a tight labor market, rising labor costs, and decreasing affordability. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential tightening of the housing supply, which could exacerbate affordability issues and make it even more challenging to attract and retain top talent in the area.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #9 OF 50

# Philadelphia

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington

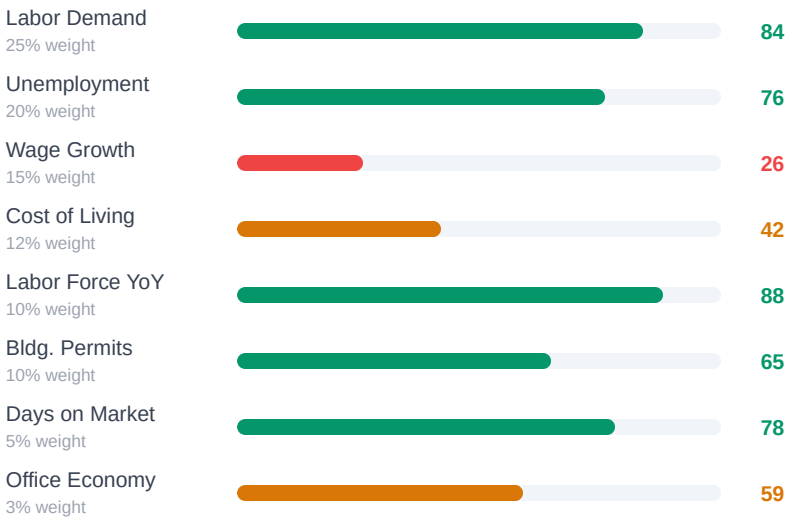
**A-**

GOOD

66.1th percentile

Rank 9 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT **4.4%** of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY **+2.1%** avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.8%** nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY **+1.2%** civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS **+16.4%** residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET **49 days** median, +8.9% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**STRONG**

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area has earned an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking it at the 66.1th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier at the 84th percentile, and its labor force growth, which is expanding at a rate of +1.23% YoY, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile. These metrics signal a city with genuine job growth and an increasing workforce supply.

**Labor Demand**

The employment growth rate in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is +0.83% YoY, combined with a +1.300% deviation in weekly hours above its own 12-month trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing real job growth, with hours worked increasing above the trend, suggesting that businesses are hiring and workers are taking on more hours. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to expand or relocate to the area.

**Unemployment**

The unemployment rate in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is 4.40%, which ranks at the 76th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. With an unemployment rate below the national average, businesses may face challenges in finding available workers, which could lead to upward pressure on wages. However, this also suggests a skilled and employed workforce, which can be beneficial for businesses looking for talented workers.

**Wage Growth**

The year-over-year wage growth in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is +2.14%, which ranks below average at the 26th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but at a slower pace than in many other cities. While this may help keep costs under control for businesses, it also means that workers may not have as much bargaining power or purchasing power as they would in cities with faster wage growth.

**Cost of Living**

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington has a cost of living score that ranks at the 42nd percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $228/sqft to $32.59/hr, or approximately 7.00. The fact that the PSF is falling by -0.9% YoY relative to wages is a key driver of its near-median affordability score. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage for businesses, as they may not need to offer wage premiums to compensate for a high cost of living.

**Labor Force Growth**

The labor force in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is growing at a rate of +1.23% YoY, which ranks in the top tier at the 88th percentile. This expanding workforce supply is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it indicates a growing pool of potential workers. This can help mitigate the challenges of a tight labor market and provide businesses with the talent they need to grow and expand.

**Building Permits**

The number of building permits in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington has increased by +16.37% YoY, which ranks above average at the 65th percentile. This increase in building permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which can help improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. This is a positive sign for businesses, as it indicates that the city is investing in its infrastructure and preparing for future growth.

**Days on Market**

The median days on market for homes in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is currently 49 days, with a year-over-year increase of +8.9%. This ranks at the 78th percentile, indicating a relatively slow market. For workers relocating to the city, this means that they may have more time to find a home and negotiate a price, making the city more accessible to newcomers.

**Office Economy**

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington has an office economy score that ranks at the 59th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers at 2.82 out of 5. This suggests a deep talent pool suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. While the city may not be as dominant in these sectors as some of its peers, it still offers a significant advantage for businesses looking to tap into a knowledgeable and skilled workforce.

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, expanding workforce supply, and relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the moderate wage growth, which may limit the bargaining power and purchasing power of workers, potentially affecting the local consumer demand and the overall attractiveness of the city for certain types of businesses.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #10 OF 50

# Kansas City

Kansas City

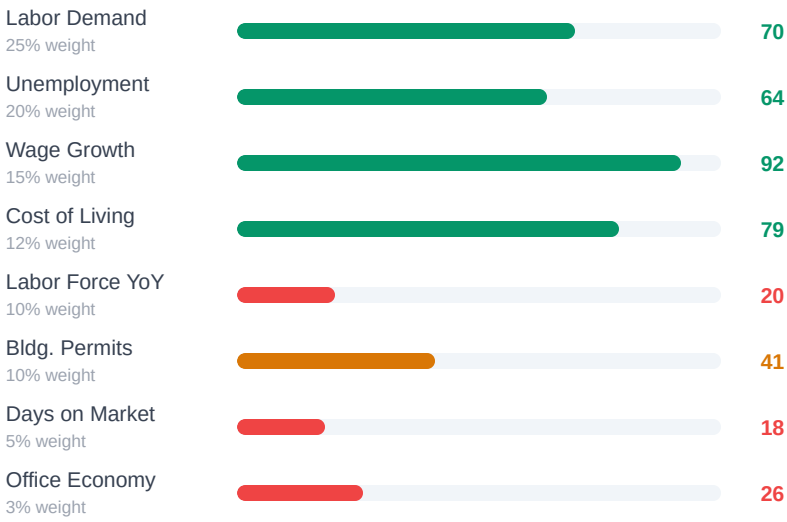
**B+**

ABOVE AVERAGE

61.4th percentile

Rank 10 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT<br>**3.9%**<br>of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY<br>**+7.3%**<br>avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH<br>**+0.7%**<br>nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY<br>**-2.1%**<br>civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS<br>**-3.3%**<br>residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET<br>**50 days**<br>median, -2.0% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**STRONG**

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Kansas City earns an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 61.4th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 7.35%, and its above-average labor demand, driven by employment growth of 0.73% and hours worked 0.665% above trend. These metrics suggest a city with a robust job market and rising labor costs.

### Labor Demand

Kansas City's labor demand is characterized by employment growth of 0.73% and weekly hours 0.665% above its own 12-month trend, resulting in a composite score of 5.99, which ranks at the 70th percentile. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours worked are increasing. The city's labor market is experiencing a period of growth, with employers adding jobs and workers putting in more hours.

### Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Kansas City is 3.90%, ranking at the 64th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. With a low unemployment rate, businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. This tight market can lead to upward pressure on wages, making it essential for businesses to consider this factor in their hiring strategies.

### Wage Growth

Wages in Kansas City are growing at a rate of 7.35% year-over-year, placing the city at the 92nd percentile. This rapid wage growth indicates a strong labor market, where workers have significant bargaining power, and employers may face rising labor costs. As a result, workers in Kansas City have increasing purchasing power, which can benefit local businesses that rely on consumer spending.

### Cost of Living

Kansas City has a cost of living score that ranks at the 79th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $195/sqft to $36.37/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.36. Although the city's cost of living is not extremely low, its relative affordability compared to peer cities can be a talent attraction advantage, as workers may not require significant wage premiums to maintain their standard of living. However, the 1.6% year-over-year increase in PSF suggests that affordability may be decreasing over time.

### Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Kansas City is shrinking at a rate of -2.09% year-over-year, ranking at the 20th percentile. This contraction in the labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may struggle to find qualified workers to fill open positions. The

declining labor force can limit the city's ability to support rapid business growth or expansion.

**Building Permits**

The number of residential building permits in Kansas City has decreased by 3.34% year-over-year, ranking at the 41st percentile. This decline in permits suggests that the city's housing supply is not expanding at a rate that keeps pace with demand, which can lead to future affordability challenges and make it more difficult for workers to relocate to the area.

**Days on Market**

The median days on market for homes in Kansas City is 50 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 2.0%. This relatively fast pace of home sales, ranking at the 18th percentile, indicates a competitive market that may be challenging for relocating workers to find affordable housing. The quick turnover of homes can make it difficult for businesses to attract talent from other areas, as workers may be deterred by the competitive housing market.

**Office Economy**

Kansas City's professional and office worker share is relatively low, ranking at the 26th percentile, with a composite score of 1.90. This suggests that the city's talent pool is not as deep in specialized office roles, making it less suited for businesses in the tech, finance, or consulting sectors. However, the city may be more attractive to businesses in industries that are less dependent on a highly specialized office workforce.

In conclusion, Kansas City offers businesses a strong labor market with rising wages and a relatively tight unemployment rate, making it an attractive location for companies that can adapt to these conditions. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering Kansas City is the shrinking labor force, which can limit the city's ability to support rapid growth or expansion, and may require companies to invest in talent development and retention strategies to overcome this challenge.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #11 OF 50

# Dallas

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington

**B+**

ABOVE AVERAGE

61.3th percentile

Rank 11 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Labor Demand | 25% weight | 82 |
| Unemployment | 20% weight | 36 |
| Wage Growth | 15% weight | 54 |
| Cost of Living | 12% weight | 88 |
| Labor Force YoY | 10% weight | 78 |
| Bldg. Permits | 10% weight | 20 |
| Days on Market | 5% weight | 46 |
| Office Economy | 3% weight | 94 |

## KEY INDICATORS

**UNEMPLOYMENT**
**4.4%**
of civilian labor force

**WAGE GROWTH YOY**
**+4.0%**
avg hourly earnings

**EMPLOYMENT GROWTH**
**+1.0%**
nonfarm payrolls YoY

**LABOR FORCE YOY**
**+0.6%**
civilian labor force growth

**BUILDING PERMITS**
**-15.9%**
residential YoY (3mo avg)

**DAYS ON MARKET**
**62 days**
median, -1.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**STRONG**

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 61.3th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier at the 82nd percentile, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked at the 88th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 1.00% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.903% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend.

### Labor Demand

The combination of a 1.00% employment growth rate and a 0.903% increase in weekly hours above trend signals genuine demand expansion in the Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area. This indicates that not only are more jobs being added, but existing workers are also working more hours, suggesting a strong and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 6.60 further reinforces this positive outlook.

### Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington stands at 4.40%, which ranks below average at the 36th percentile. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it somewhat easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the relatively low unemployment rate still implies some level of competition for talent, potentially leading to moderate wage pressure.

### Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the metro area is 4.03%, placing it near the median at the 54th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but at a manageable rate. For workers, this translates into somewhat stronger purchasing power, which can contribute to local consumer demand.

### Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $198/sqft to $38.10/hr, or 5.20, and a year-over-year decrease of 2.5% in PSF, Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is highly affordable, ranking at the 88th percentile. This affordability is a significant talent attraction advantage, as businesses can offer competitive wages without needing large premiums to offset high living costs.

### Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area is growing at a rate of 0.62% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking at the 78th percentile. This expansion in labor force supply is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it indicates a growing pool of potential workers.

### Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -15.89%, indicating a tightening in housing supply. This decline suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation might be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand.

**Days on Market**

Homes in the Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington area are currently sitting on the market for a median of 62 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 1.6%. This relatively fast market, ranking near the median at the 46th percentile, can make it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing, potentially affecting a business's ability to attract talent.

**Office Economy**

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is significant, with a composite score ranking it at the 94th percentile. This deep talent pool makes the city highly suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and headquarters operations, but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and a highly affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, signaled by the sharp decline in building permits, which could impact future workforce accommodation and affordability.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #12 OF 50

# Baltimore

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson

**B+**

ABOVE AVERAGE

60.5th percentile

Rank 12 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT<br>**3.9%**<br>of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY<br>**+6.0%**<br>avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH<br>**-0.5%**<br>nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY<br>**-0.5%**<br>civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS<br>**-2.3%**<br>residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET<br>**46 days**<br>median, +17.9% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**WEAK**

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area has an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 60.5th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 3.90% and high wage growth of +5.99% year-over-year, indicating a tight labor market with rising labor costs. The labor demand composite score, however, is in the bottom tier at 18th percentile, suggesting a more nuanced economic environment.

### Labor Demand

The employment growth rate is -0.47% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.175% from the city's own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 3.64. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The negative employment growth rate indicates that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation.

### Unemployment

The unemployment rate is 3.90%, ranking in the top tier at the 82nd percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face challenges in finding available workers, leading to potential wage pressure. With such a low unemployment rate, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

### Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate is +5.99%, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile, indicating fast-rising labor costs for employers. This rapid wage growth is good for worker purchasing power, as employees will have more disposable income to spend in the local economy. However, it may pose a challenge for businesses looking to keep labor costs under control.

### Cost of Living

The city has a cost of living score ranking it in the top tier at the 85th percentile, with a PSF of $215/sqft and average hourly earnings of $37.96, resulting in a ratio of 5.66. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling by -2.7% year-over-year further enhances the city's affordability.

### Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of -0.45% year-over-year, ranking in the above-average tier at the 60th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is contracting, rather than expanding, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring in the city. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in workforce development programs.

### Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -2.34%, ranking near the median at the 43rd percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability challenges and constraints on workforce accommodation. As the city's population grows, the lack of new housing supply may drive up housing costs and make it harder for workers to relocate.

**Days on Market**

The current median days on market is 46 days, with a year-over-year increase of +17.9%, ranking in the top tier at the 96th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, this trend may also suggest a normalization of the market after a period of rapid growth.

**Office Economy**

The city has an office economy score ranking it below average at the 35th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers indicating a less deep talent pool. This city is less suited for businesses that require a large pool of specialized office workers, such as tech or finance companies, but may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area offers a unique combination of a tight labor market, rising wages, and relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for businesses that can adapt to these conditions. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the declining labor force growth and tightening housing supply, which may pose challenges for hiring and workforce accommodation in the long term.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #13 OF 50

# Orlando

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford

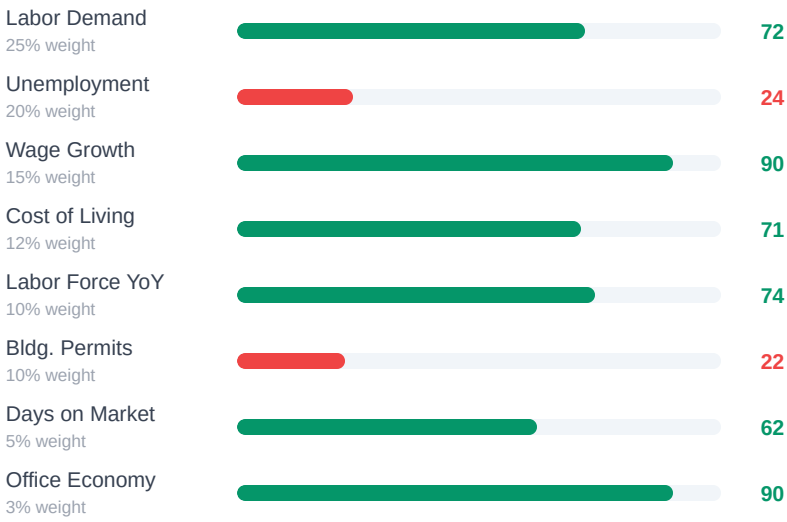
**B+**

ABOVE AVERAGE

60.2th percentile

Rank 13 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT **4.6%** of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY **+6.1%** avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.8%** nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY **+0.4%** civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS **-15.7%** residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET **77 days** median, -2.5% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**STRONG**

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 60.2th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the 72nd percentile, and its top-tier wage growth, which has increased by 6.12% year-over-year. These metrics signal a city with a growing economy and rising labor costs.

### Labor Demand

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has seen employment growth of 0.80% year-over-year and a weekly hours deviation of 0.783% above its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, a sign of a strong and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 6.20 further reinforces this trend, ranking the city in the 72nd percentile.

### Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is 4.60%, which ranks in the 24th percentile, indicating a relatively loose labor market. This means that there is some slack in the market, making it easier for businesses to hire workers without facing intense competition. However, this also implies that local consumer demand may be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate.

### Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is 6.12%, ranking in the 90th percentile, which is a top-tier performance. This rapid wage growth signals rising labor costs for employers, but it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power, which can benefit local businesses. The strong wage growth is a double-edged sword, offering benefits to workers but increasing costs for employers.

### Cost of Living

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has a cost of living score that ranks in the 71st percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $222/sqft to $34.05/hr, or 6.52. The fact that the PSF is falling by 3.1% year-over-year relative to wages makes the city more affordable. This affordability advantage can attract talent without requiring wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to hire.

### Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has grown by 0.38% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, which can support hiring capacity and business expansion. The increasing labor force can help meet the demands of a growing economy.

**Building Permits**

The number of building permits in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has decreased by 15.65% year-over-year, indicating a tightening housing supply. This decline in permits signals that the city's housing supply may not be expanding fast enough to keep up with demand, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

**Days on Market**

The median days on market for homes in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is 77 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 2.5%. This relatively fast market means that homes are selling quickly, which can make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The fast-paced market may require workers to act quickly to secure housing, which can be competitive.

**Office Economy**

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking in the 90th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that require specialized knowledge workers. However, it may be less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented economies.

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with growing demand and a deep talent pool, particularly in professional and office sectors. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, signaled by the decline in building permits, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #14 OF 50

# Pittsburgh

Pittsburgh

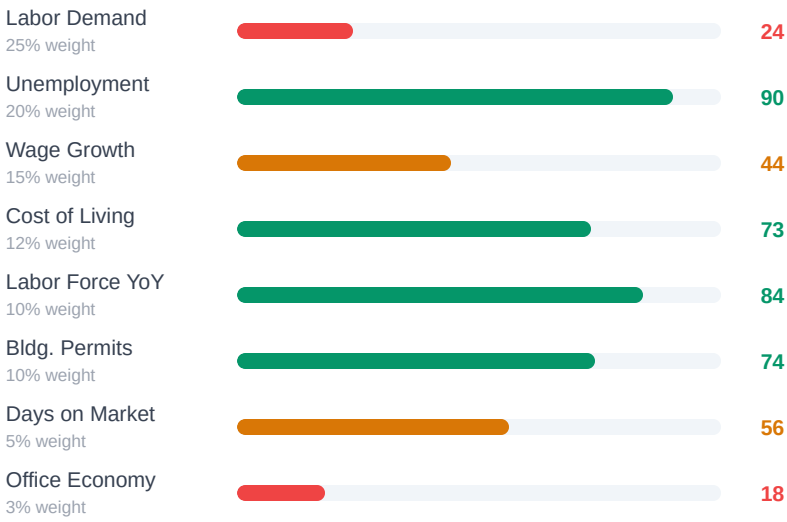
**B**

AVERAGE

58.4th percentile

Rank 14 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT **3.9%** of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY **+3.3%** avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.1%** nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY **+1.1%** civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS **+24.7%** residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET **54 days** median, +3.9% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**SQUEEZE**

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Pittsburgh has an overall grade of B, ranking 58.4th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its low unemployment rate of 3.90% and a cost of living score that indicates relative affordability. The city's labor demand composite score is 4.06, which is below average, and its wage growth is near median at +3.33% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a city with a tight labor market but moderate labor cost pressures.

### Labor Demand

Pittsburgh's employment growth rate is -0.05% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating +0.173% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a scenario where hours are above trend during job losses, which suggests a survivor squeeze. This combination signals that while there may not be significant job additions, existing workers are taking on more hours, potentially indicating a need for more labor supply. The labor demand composite score of 4.06 is below average, ranking in the 24th percentile.

### Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Pittsburgh is 3.90%, which ranks in the 90th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This tight market means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as there are fewer unemployed individuals seeking work, leading to potential wage pressure. For a business trying to hire in Pittsburgh, this means being prepared to offer competitive wages to attract top talent.

### Wage Growth

Wage growth in Pittsburgh is +3.33% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising but not at an alarming rate. For workers, this means their purchasing power is increasing, which can be beneficial for local consumer demand.

### Cost of Living

Pittsburgh has a cost of living score that indicates it is more affordable than many of its peers, with a ratio of $170/sqft to $33.44/hr, and the price per square foot is falling by -1.2% year-over-year. Ranking in the 73rd percentile for affordability, this means Pittsburgh has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford a higher quality of life without necessitating wage premiums.

### Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Pittsburgh is growing at a rate of +1.07% year-over-year, which is in the top tier, ranking in the 84th percentile. This expanding labor force supply is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it indicates a growing pool of potential workers. This growth can help mitigate some of the challenges posed by the tight labor market.

### Building Permits

Building permits in Pittsburgh are increasing by +24.71% year-over-year, ranking above average in the 74th percentile. This significant increase in residential building permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which can improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. This is a positive signal for future workforce attraction and retention.

**Days on Market**

The median days on market for homes in Pittsburgh is 54 days, with a year-over-year increase of +3.9%. Ranking in the 56th percentile, this indicates a near-median pace of home sales. For workers relocating to Pittsburgh, this suggests a relatively accessible housing market, neither extremely competitive nor overly slow.

**Office Economy**

Pittsburgh's professional and office worker share ranks in the bottom tier, at the 18th percentile. This indicates a less deep talent pool in professional and office sectors compared to other cities, making it less suited for businesses that require a large number of tech, finance, consulting, or HQ roles. However, it may be more suited for industries with different workforce needs.

In conclusion, Pittsburgh offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market with moderate wage growth and an affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the city's below-average labor demand and the potential for a survivor squeeze, which could impact hiring and labor costs in the long term.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #15 OF 50

# Seattle

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue

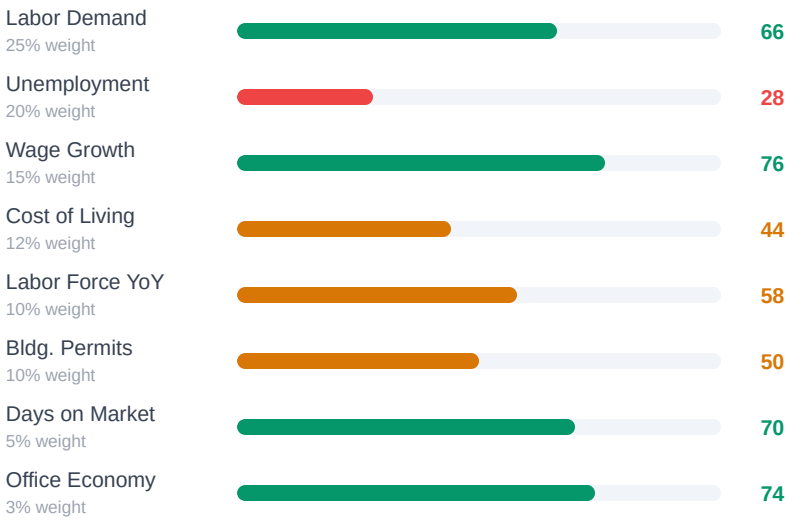
**B**

AVERAGE

55.3th percentile

Rank 15 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT **4.8%** of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY **+5.4%** avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.9%** nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY **-0.5%** civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS **N/A** residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET **51 days** median, +8.5% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**STRONG**

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 55.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average labor demand and strong wage growth, at 66th and 76th percentiles, respectively. The city's economic character is defined by these two metrics, which signal a growing economy with increasing labor costs. With a labor demand composite score of 5.94 and wage growth of 5.44% year-over-year, Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue presents a unique blend of opportunities and challenges for businesses.

### Labor Demand

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area has an employment growth rate of 0.88% year-over-year and a weekly hours deviation of 0.406% above its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a period of job growth, with hours worked increasing above the trend, suggesting that businesses are hiring and workers are taking on more hours. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to expand or relocate to the area.

### Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 4.80%, which is below the national average, ranking in the 28th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market, making it more challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain top talent in this competitive market.

### Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 5.44%, which is above average, ranking in the 76th percentile. This rapid wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but it also means that workers have stronger purchasing power, which can be beneficial for businesses that rely on local consumer demand. However, this may also lead to higher operational costs for businesses.

### Cost of Living

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has a cost of living score that ranks in the 44th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $427/sqft to $48.08/hr, resulting in a ratio of 8.88. While not extremely affordable, the city's cost of living is near the median compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is falling by 2.5% year-over-year is a positive sign for affordability. This means that the city may not require significant wage premiums to attract talent, making it a relatively competitive location for businesses.

### Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is growing at a rate of -0.54% year-over-year, which is near the median. This indicates that the labor force supply is slightly contracting, presenting a potential structural headwind for hiring. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in workforce development programs to address this challenge.

**Building Permits**

Data on the year-over-year change in building permits is not available for Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue. However, this metric is crucial for understanding the future trajectory of housing supply and affordability. Without this information, it is difficult to assess the city's ability to accommodate a growing workforce and the potential impact on future affordability.

**Days on Market**

The median days on market for homes in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 51 days, with an 8.5% year-over-year increase, ranking in the 70th percentile. This suggests a slower market, which can be beneficial for workers relocating to the city, as they have more time to find a home. However, this also indicates a potential normalization of the housing market, which could impact demand and prices in the future.

**Office Economy**

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking in the 74th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. However, it may be less suitable for industries that are more industrial or logistics-dominant.

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area offers businesses a unique combination of growing labor demand and strong wage growth, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand or relocate. However, the city's tight labor market and rising labor costs present significant challenges that decision-makers must carefully consider when evaluating this location. Ultimately, businesses must weigh the benefits of a deep professional talent pool against the potential risks of a competitive hiring environment and increasing operational costs.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #16 OF 50

# Tampa

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater

**B-**

BELOW AVERAGE

54.8th percentile

Rank 16 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT **4.7%** of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY **+5.1%** avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.9%** nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY **+0.3%** civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS **-10.1%** residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET **76 days** median, -3.8% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**STRONG**

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 54.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its above-average labor demand, driven by a 0.92% employment growth rate and a 0.120% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend, as well as its strong wage growth of 5.13% year-over-year. These metrics signal a city with genuine demand expansion and rising labor costs.

**Labor Demand**

The employment growth rate of 0.92% and weekly hours deviation of 0.120% above trend indicate a labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a strong and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 5.71, ranking at the 60th percentile, further supports this assessment.

**Unemployment**

The unemployment rate of 4.70% ranks at the 16th percentile, indicating a relatively loose labor market. This means that there is some slack in the market, making it easier for businesses to hire workers without facing intense competition. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand compared to tighter labor markets.

**Wage Growth**

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 5.13% is above average, ranking at the 72nd percentile. This signals fast wage growth, which implies rising labor costs for employers but also increasing purchasing power for workers. Businesses should factor in the potential for higher labor costs when considering this location.

**Cost of Living**

With a cost of living ratio of 6.22, based on $232/sqft (decreasing by 6.1% year-over-year) versus $37.29/hr, Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater ranks at the 83rd percentile in terms of affordability. This means the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums.

**Labor Force Growth**

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 0.34% year-over-year, ranking at the 70th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire. The growing labor force provides a structural advantage for companies seeking to expand their operations.

**Building Permits**

The year-over-year change in building permits is -10.10%, ranking at the 31st percentile. This decline suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability challenges and constraints on workforce accommodation. Businesses should consider the potential long-term implications of a tightening housing market on their ability to attract and retain talent.

**Days on Market**

The current median days on market is 76 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 3.8%. This ranks at the 66th percentile, indicating a relatively fast-paced market. For workers relocating to this city, the housing market is competitive, but the decreasing days on market suggests some normalization, making it slightly more accessible.

**Office Economy**

With an office/professional worker share composite score of 3.55, ranking at the 82nd percentile, Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses requiring specialized professional roles but may be less ideal for those with primarily industrial or logistics-dominated operations.

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area offers businesses a unique combination of above-average labor demand, strong wage growth, and relative affordability. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the tightening housing market, signaled by the decline in building permits, which could lead to future affordability challenges and impact the city's ability to attract and retain talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #17 OF 50

# Miami

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach

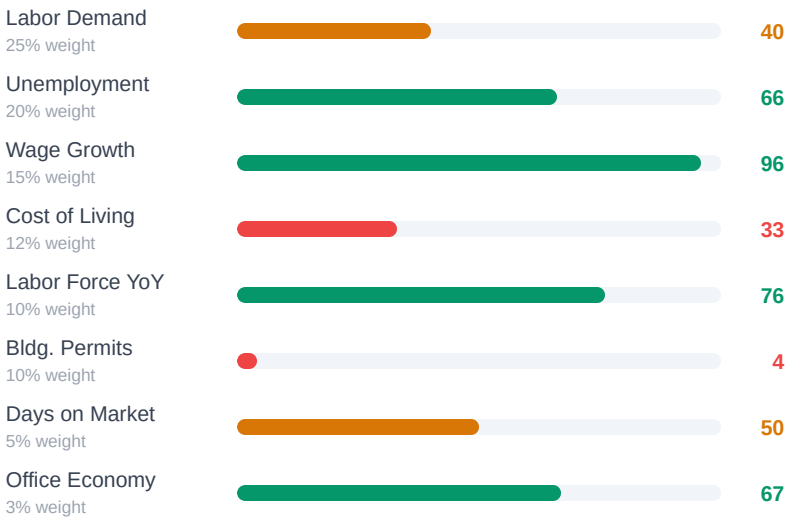
**B-**

BELOW AVERAGE

54.1th percentile

Rank 17 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT **3.7%** of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY **+7.7%** avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.3%** nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY **+0.4%** civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS **-34.1%** residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET **85 days** median, -4.5% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**STRONG**

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 54.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth rate of 7.68% year-over-year and its low cost of living percentile rank of 33, indicating a relatively expensive city. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to manage labor costs while attracting talent.

**Labor Demand**

The employment growth rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 0.35% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating 0.285% above the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours are increasing, indicating a growing need for labor. However, the near-median percentile rank of 40 suggests that this demand is not exceptionally strong compared to other cities.

**Unemployment**

The unemployment rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 3.70%, ranking at the 66th percentile, which indicates a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market also implies upward pressure on wages.

**Wage Growth**

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 7.68%, ranking at the 96th percentile, indicating very fast wage growth. This rapid increase in wages suggests that employer labor costs are rising quickly, while worker purchasing power is also increasing. Businesses should be prepared for higher labor costs in this environment.

**Cost of Living**

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has a cost of living percentile rank of 33, indicating that it is relatively expensive compared to its peers, with a PSF to earnings ratio of $355/sqft to $35.24/hr, or 10.07. However, the PSF is falling by 0.8% year-over-year, which slightly mitigates the expense. This relatively high cost of living may make it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

**Labor Force Growth**

The civilian labor force in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is growing at a rate of 0.39% year-over-year, ranking at the 76th percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth suggests that businesses will have a larger pool of potential workers to hire from, making it easier to find talent.

**Building Permits**

The number of residential building permits in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has decreased by 34.10% year-over-year, ranking at the 4th percentile, indicating a significant tightening of housing supply. This sharp decline in permits suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand.

**Days on Market**

The median days on market for homes in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 85 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 4.5%, ranking at the 50th percentile. This indicates a relatively competitive market for workers relocating to the city, as homes are selling fairly quickly. However, the decrease in days on market suggests that the market may be heating up.

**Office Economy**

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has an office economy percentile rank of 67, indicating a deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. This city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but may be less suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area offers businesses a growing labor force and a deep talent pool in professional sectors, but also presents challenges such as high labor costs and a relatively expensive cost of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which may impact future affordability and workforce accommodation, making it essential to factor this into long-term business plans.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #18 OF 50

# Los Angeles

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim

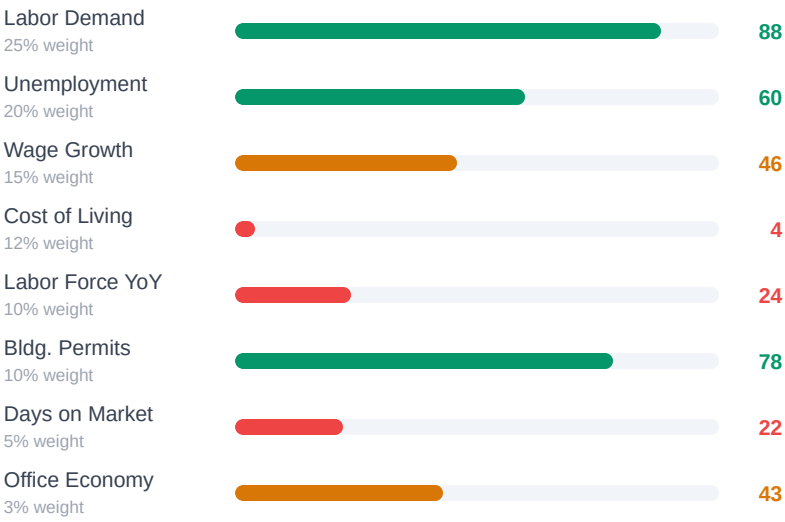
**B-**

BELOW AVERAGE

53.9th percentile

Rank 18 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT **4.8%** of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY **+3.4%** avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.8%** nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY **-1.9%** civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS **+26.8%** residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET **55 days** median, -3.5% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**STRONG**

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 53.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier at the 88th percentile, and its high cost of living, ranked at the 4th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 1.83% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.151% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend.

### Labor Demand

The combination of a 1.83% employment growth rate and a 0.151% increase in weekly hours signals genuine demand expansion in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area. This indicates that the city is experiencing a period of job growth, with hours worked above the trend, suggesting that businesses are hiring and workers are absorbing the increased workload. The top-tier ranking of the labor demand composite score further reinforces this notion.

### Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area is 4.80%, ranking at the 60th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight labor market also suggests that workers have more bargaining power.

### Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area is 3.39%, ranking near the median at the 46th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but not at an alarming rate. Workers in the area are experiencing a modest increase in purchasing power, which can have a positive impact on local consumer demand.

### Cost of Living

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has a cost of living ranked at the 4th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $647/sqft to $41.54/hr, resulting in a ratio of 15.58. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The low affordability score means that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract and retain talent, as the high cost of living can be a deterrent for workers.

### Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area is contracting at a rate of -1.91% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 24th percentile. This decline in labor force supply suggests that businesses may face structural headwinds in hiring,

as the pool of available workers is shrinking. The implication is that companies may need to be more competitive in their hiring practices to attract the limited talent available.

**Building Permits**

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has experienced a 26.84% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, ranking above average at the 78th percentile. This surge in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which can lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce. The increase in permits is a positive signal for future workforce attraction and retention.

**Days on Market**

The median days on market in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area is 55 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -3.5%. This relatively fast pace of home sales indicates a competitive market, which can make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The below-average ranking of days on market at the 22nd percentile further reinforces this notion.

**Office Economy**

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has a professional and office worker share ranked near the median at the 43rd percentile, with a composite score of 2.33. This suggests that the city has a moderately deep talent pool in professional and office sectors, making it suitable for businesses in tech, finance, and consulting. However, it may not be as attractive for industries that require a large pool of specialized workers.

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and an expanding housing supply, which can support workforce growth and attraction. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the high cost of living, which can make it challenging to attract and retain talent without offering wage premiums. This may impact businesses' ability to compete in the labor market and ultimately affect their bottom line.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #19 OF 50

# Columbus

Columbus

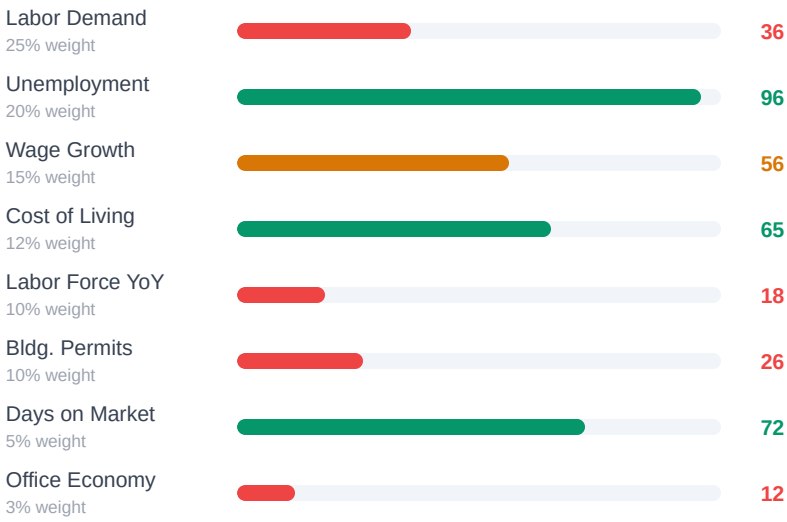
**B-**

BELOW AVERAGE

52.8th percentile

Rank 19 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT<br>**3.3%**<br>of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY<br>**+4.2%**<br>avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH<br>**+0.1%**<br>nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY<br>**-2.2%**<br>civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS<br>**-15.0%**<br>residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET<br>**48 days**<br>median, +6.7% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**STRONG**

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Columbus, with an overall grade of B- and a composite score ranking it at the 52.8th percentile among 50 US metros, is characterized by its low unemployment rate of 3.30% and a labor demand composite score of 4.88, which ranks below average at the 36th percentile. The city's economic character is most defined by its tight labor market and moderate wage growth. Specifically, the combination of a +0.06% employment growth rate and +0.492% weekly hours deviation from trend signals a genuine demand expansion, albeit a slow one.

### Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Columbus is +0.06% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating +0.492% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, indicating that jobs are being added and hours are running above trend. However, the below-average labor demand composite score of 4.88 suggests that this expansion is not particularly strong.

### Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Columbus is 3.30%, ranking at the 96th percentile, which means the market is extremely tight. This tight market implies that businesses may face significant challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is small, and wage pressure is likely to be high. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

### Wage Growth

Wage growth in Columbus is +4.15% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 56th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. At the same time, workers are experiencing an increase in purchasing power, which can have positive effects on local consumer demand.

### Cost of Living

Columbus has a cost of living score that ranks at the 65th percentile, with a PSF of $205/sqft and an average hourly earnings of $34.84, resulting in a ratio of 5.88. This indicates that the city is slightly above average in terms of affordability. The stable YoY change in PSF (+0.0%) suggests that affordability is not significantly improving or deteriorating. This relative affordability can be a talent attraction advantage, as workers may not require significant wage premiums to maintain their standard of living.

### Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Columbus is shrinking at a rate of -2.20% year-over-year, ranking at the 18th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a significant structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in training and development programs to upskill existing employees.

### Building Permits

The number of building permits in Columbus has decreased by -14.98% year-over-year, ranking at the 26th percentile. This sharp decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which can lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing in the future. This may pose a risk to workforce accommodation and attraction, as relocating workers may face challenges in finding affordable housing.

**Days on Market**

The median days on market in Columbus is currently 48 days, with a +6.7% year-over-year increase. This rising days on market, combined with the above-average percentile rank of 72nd, indicates a slower market. For workers relocating to this city, this means that they may have a more accessible and less competitive housing market, with more time to find a suitable home.

**Office Economy**

Columbus has a professional and office worker share of 0.80, ranking at the 12th percentile. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors, making it less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting. However, the city may be more suitable for industries with different talent requirements, such as logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, Columbus offers a business a tight labor market with moderate wage growth, which can be both a challenge and an opportunity. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the shrinking labor force supply, which poses a significant structural headwind for hiring and may require businesses to adapt their talent attraction and retention strategies.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #20 OF 50

# Atlanta

Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell

**B-**

BELOW AVERAGE

51.8th percentile

Rank 20 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT **3.4%** of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY **+3.1%** avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.5%** nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY **+1.2%** civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS **+15.2%** residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET **60 days** median, 0.0% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**SQUEEZE**

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 51.8th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile, and its tight unemployment market, with a rate of 3.40% ranking in the top tier at the 84th percentile. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to hire and expand.

**Labor Demand**

The employment growth rate in Atlanta is -0.46% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating 0.595% above the city's own 12-month trend. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 3.06 is in the bottom tier, indicating payrolls are contracting.

**Unemployment**

The unemployment rate in Atlanta is 3.40%, which ranks in the top tier at the 84th percentile, indicating a tight market with low unemployment. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for talent, leading to potential wage pressure. With such a low unemployment rate, it may be harder for companies to staff their operations.

**Wage Growth**

The year-over-year wage growth in Atlanta is +3.11%, which ranks below average at the 36th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively, and worker purchasing power is increasing. However, the relatively slow wage growth may not be sufficient to attract top talent from other cities.

**Cost of Living**

Atlanta has a cost of living score that ranks above average at the 75th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $194/sqft to $37.62/hr, or 5.16. This means that the city is relatively more affordable compared to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage without requiring significant wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling by 0.5% year-over-year further supports the city's affordability.

**Labor Force Growth**

The civilian labor force in Atlanta is growing at a rate of +1.18% year-over-year, which ranks in the top tier at the 86th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, providing a positive environment for hiring and business growth. As the labor force grows, companies will have a larger pool of potential employees to choose from.

**Building Permits**

The number of residential building permits in Atlanta is increasing by +15.21% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 63rd percentile. This signals that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. As a result, the city is likely to remain attractive to relocating workers and businesses.

**Days on Market**

The median days on market for homes in Atlanta is 60 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%, ranking below average at the 36th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, which may be competitive for workers relocating to the city. However, the stable days on market suggests a balanced market that is not overly favorable to buyers or sellers.

**Office Economy**

Atlanta's professional and office worker share ranks below average at the 31st percentile, with a composite score of 2.10. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors, making it less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies. However, the city may be more suitable for industries with less specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, Atlanta offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and an expanding labor force, but its tight unemployment market and moderate wage growth may pose challenges for hiring and talent attraction. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's low labor demand, which may indicate a competitive environment for businesses looking to expand or establish operations in the area.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #21 OF 50

# San Antonio

San Antonio-New Braunfels

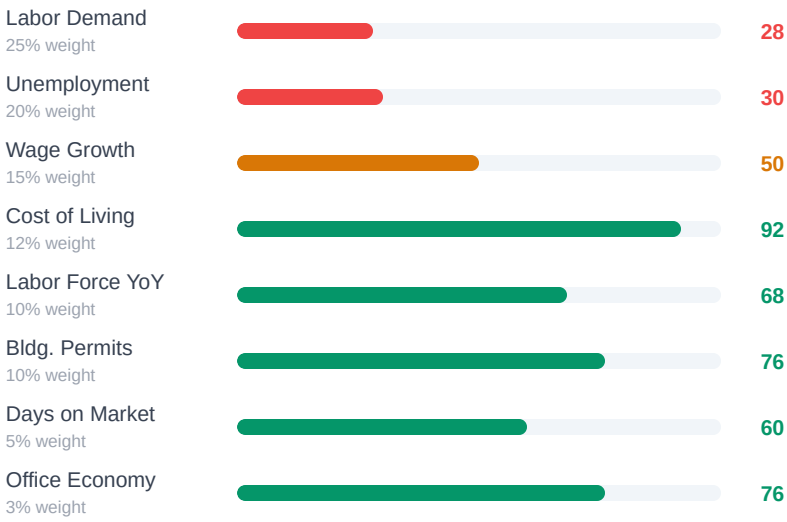
**B-**

BELOW AVERAGE

51.1th percentile

Rank 21 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT **4.5%** of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY **+3.7%** avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.5%** nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY **+0.2%** civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS **+26.0%** residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET **71 days** median, -2.7% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**GROWING**

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 51.1th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high cost of living affordability, with a percentile rank of 92, and its near-median wage growth of 3.73% year-over-year. The labor demand composite score of 4.36, ranking at the 28th percentile, also plays a significant role in shaping the city's economic landscape.

### Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 0.51% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.651% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a labor market that is not experiencing genuine demand expansion, as the hours worked are below trend despite job growth. The labor demand composite score of 4.36, ranking at the 28th percentile, further supports this assessment.

### Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 4.50%, ranking at the 30th percentile, indicating a labor market with some slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may find it relatively easier to staff, but may also face weaker local consumer demand. The unemployment rate suggests that the market is not overly tight, giving employers some flexibility in hiring.

### Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 3.73%, ranking at the 50th percentile, indicating a moderate pace of wage increases. This rate of wage growth suggests that employer labor costs are rising, but at a pace that is neither extremely fast nor stagnant. Workers in this city can expect to see their purchasing power increase, but not dramatically.

### Cost of Living

San Antonio-New Braunfels has a cost of living percentile rank of 92, making it one of the more affordable cities relative to its peers. The PSF to earnings ratio is $170/sqft vs $33.17/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.13, and the PSF is falling by 3.4% year-over-year. This affordability advantage means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums to compensate for a high cost of living.

### Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Antonio-New Braunfels is growing at a rate of 0.23% year-over-year, ranking at the 68th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, albeit slowly, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire in this city. The growing labor force suggests that hiring capacity is increasing, but may not be rapid enough to support very fast-paced growth.

**Building Permits**

The number of residential building permits in San Antonio-New Braunfels is increasing by 25.98% year-over-year, ranking at the 76th percentile. This significant increase in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. The rising permits signal a positive outlook for future affordability and workforce accommodation in this city.

**Days on Market**

The median days on market for homes in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 71 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 2.7%. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, although the decrease in days on market is modest. For workers relocating to this city, the housing market is competitive, but not extremely so, making it accessible for those looking to move.

**Office Economy**

San Antonio-New Braunfels has an office economy percentile rank of 76, indicating a deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. This city is well-suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions, but may not be as suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area offers businesses a unique combination of affordability and a growing labor force, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's labor demand, which is not experiencing genuine expansion, and may require businesses to adapt their hiring strategies to the local market conditions.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #22 OF 50

# Nashville

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin

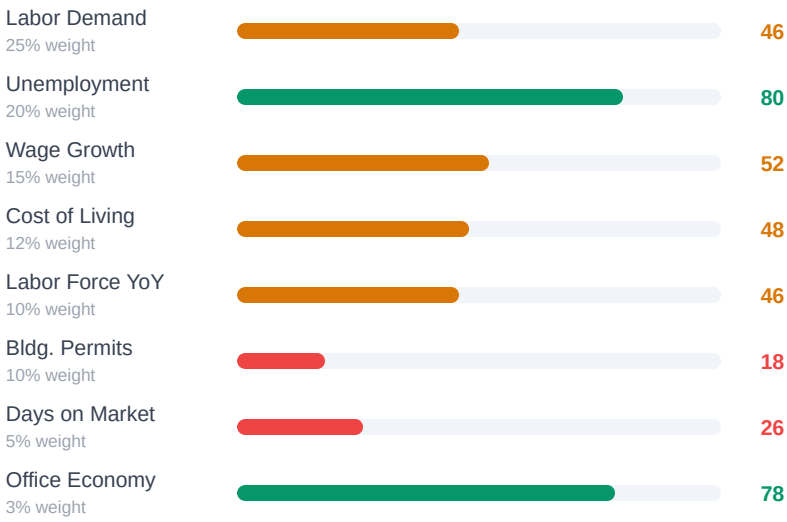
**B-**

BELOW AVERAGE

51.1th percentile

Rank 22 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT **3.2%** of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY **+3.9%** avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.7%** nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY **-1.3%** civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS **-17.8%** residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET **62 days** median, +5.1% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**STRONG**

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 51.1th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 3.20% and its near-median labor demand composite score of 5.26, indicating a mix of positive and neutral signals. The combination of these metrics suggests a relatively stable labor market with some constraints on hiring.

**Labor Demand**

The employment growth rate in Nashville is +0.65% year-over-year, and weekly hours are running +0.047% above the city's own 12-month trend. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, as jobs are being added and hours are increasing, indicating a growing need for labor. The labor demand composite score of 5.26, ranking at the 46th percentile, further supports this interpretation.

**Unemployment**

The unemployment rate in Nashville is 3.20%, ranking at the 80th percentile, which indicates a tight labor market with low unemployment. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. The tight market implies more wage pressure for employers.

**Wage Growth**

The year-over-year wage growth in Nashville is +3.92%, ranking at the 52nd percentile, which is a moderate growth rate. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely rapidly, and worker purchasing power is increasing. The moderate wage growth implies a relatively stable cost environment for businesses.

**Cost of Living**

Nashville has a cost of living score ranking at the 48th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $259/sqft to $35.74/hr, or 7.25. The city's PSF is falling by -1.1% year-over-year, which is a positive sign for affordability. This means that Nashville is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums.

**Labor Force Growth**

The civilian labor force in Nashville is shrinking at a rate of -1.30% year-over-year, ranking at the 46th percentile. This contraction in the labor force supply implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to adapt their hiring strategies to accommodate this shrinking labor pool.

**Building Permits**

The number of residential building permits in Nashville is decreasing by -17.83% year-over-year, ranking at the 18th percentile. This sharp decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. The decrease in permits is a concern for businesses relying on a stable and affordable housing market for their employees.

**Days on Market**

The median days on market for homes in Nashville is 62 days, with a year-over-year increase of +5.1%, ranking at the 26th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the rising days on market may also signal a normalization of the housing market, which could be beneficial for businesses looking to attract talent.

**Office Economy**

Nashville has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share ranking at the 78th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which rely on specialized knowledge-economy talent. However, the city may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin metro area offers businesses a relatively stable labor market with a tight unemployment rate and moderate wage growth. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force supply and tightening housing market, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #23 OF 50

# Cleveland

Cleveland

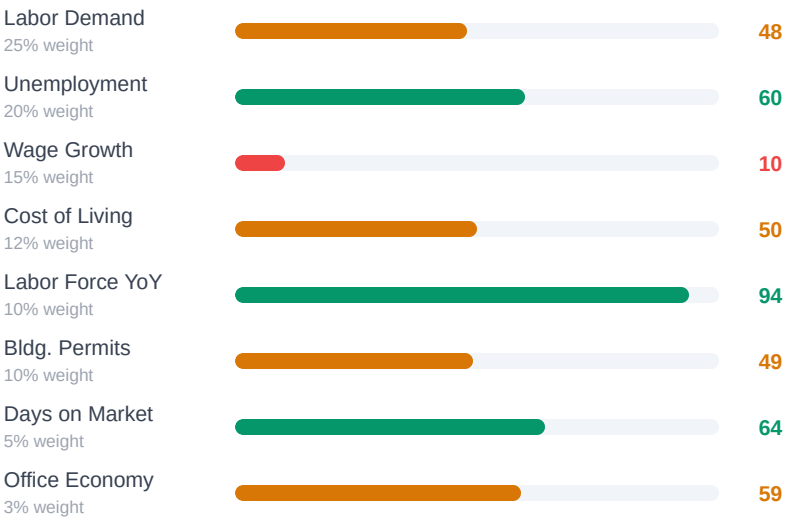
**B-**

BELOW AVERAGE

50.8th percentile

Rank 23 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT **3.4%** of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY **+0.9%** avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.6%** nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY **+1.8%** civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS **-0.6%** residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET **55 days** median, +7.8% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**STRONG**

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cleveland, with an overall grade of B- and a composite score ranking it 50.8th percentile among 50 US metros, is characterized by its near-median labor demand and above-average unemployment rate, with 3.40% of the labor force unemployed. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.27 and unemployment rate are the two metrics that most define its current economic character, with the labor force growth rate of +1.80% YoY being a notable bright spot. Specifically, the combination of +0.57% employment growth YoY and +0.170% weekly hours deviation from trend suggests a genuine demand expansion.

### Labor Demand

Cleveland's employment growth rate of +0.57% YoY and weekly hours deviation of +0.170% from its own trend signal a genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours than usual. This combination suggests that the labor market is experiencing genuine growth, rather than just a survivor squeeze where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 5.27, ranking near the median at 48th percentile, further supports this assessment.

### Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cleveland is 3.40%, ranking above average at the 60th percentile, which means the market has some slack. This rate implies that it may be slightly easier for businesses to hire in Cleveland compared to other cities, as there is a larger pool of available workers. However, this also means that local consumer demand may be somewhat weaker due to the relatively higher unemployment.

### Wage Growth

Cleveland's year-over-year wage growth rate of +0.88% is in the bottom tier, ranking at the 10th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth environment means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also signifies weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power. For businesses, this could mean a flat cost environment, but it may also indicate a less dynamic local economy.

### Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $143/sqft to $34.26/hr, ranking near the median at the 50th percentile, Cleveland is neither particularly affordable nor expensive relative to its peers. The PSF has increased by 13.5% YoY, which does not help affordability. This neutral affordability ranking means that Cleveland does not have a significant talent attraction advantage due to low costs, and businesses may need to consider wage premiums to attract top talent.

### Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cleveland is growing at a rate of +1.80% YoY, which is in the top tier, ranking at the 94th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding rapidly, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests a growing pool of potential employees. This rapid labor force growth is a significant advantage for companies seeking to expand their operations in the city.

**Building Permits**

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Cleveland is -0.61%, ranking near the median at the 49th percentile, indicating a slight tightening of housing supply. This decrease in building permits suggests that the future housing supply may not keep pace with demand, potentially leading to affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

**Days on Market**

The current median days on market in Cleveland is 55 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.8%, ranking above average at the 64th percentile. This means that homes are sitting on the market for a relatively longer period, indicating a slower market that is more accessible to relocating workers. However, this also signals a less competitive housing market, which could affect the attractiveness of the city to potential residents.

**Office Economy**

Cleveland's professional and office worker share, with a composite score of 2.82, ranks near the median at the 59th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that Cleveland is suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and industrial skills, but it may not be the best fit for companies that solely rely on a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance firms.

In conclusion, Cleveland offers businesses a unique combination of a growing labor force and a relatively slack labor market, which could facilitate hiring and expansion. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's stagnant wage growth and potential future affordability issues due to tightening housing supply, which could impact both labor costs and the attractiveness of the city to relocating workers.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #24 OF 50

# Washington DC

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria

**B-**

BELOW AVERAGE

50.3th percentile

Rank 24 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT<br>**3.8%**<br>of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY<br>**+5.8%**<br>avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH<br>**-2.0%**<br>nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY<br>**-3.6%**<br>civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS<br>**+27.4%**<br>residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET<br>**43 days**<br>median, +13.2% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**WEAK**

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 50.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its high wage growth, at 5.85% year-over-year. The combination of these metrics suggests a complex economic environment, with both opportunities and challenges for businesses.

**Labor Demand**

The employment growth rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is -1.96% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.606% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and hours worked. This suggests that businesses may face less competition for talent, but also a potentially weaker local economy.

**Unemployment**

The unemployment rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 3.80%, which ranks in the 78th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. However, this also suggests that the local workforce is highly employed, which can be beneficial for businesses that rely on local consumer demand.

**Wage Growth**

The year-over-year wage growth in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 5.85%, which is in the top tier of US metros. This rapid wage growth signals that labor costs for employers are rising quickly, but also that workers have strong bargaining power and increasing purchasing power. This can be beneficial for businesses that rely on a highly skilled and motivated workforce, but may also increase costs for employers.

**Cost of Living**

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria has a cost of living score that ranks in the 67th percentile, with a PSF of $301/sqft and average hourly earnings of $45.93/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.55. This suggests that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage for businesses, as they may not need to offer wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

**Labor Force Growth**

The civilian labor force in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is contracting at a rate of -3.61% year-over-year, which is in the bottom tier of US metros. This decline in labor force supply signals that the pool of available workers is shrinking, which can create structural headwinds

for hiring and business expansion. Businesses may need to invest in training and development programs to attract and retain talent in this environment.

**Building Permits**

The number of residential building permits in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is increasing at a rate of 27.36% year-over-year, which is above average compared to other US metros. This expansion in housing supply signals that developer confidence is strong, and future affordability and workforce accommodation may improve. This can be beneficial for businesses that rely on a highly mobile and flexible workforce.

**Days on Market**

The median days on market for homes in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 43 days, with a year-over-year increase of 13.2%, which ranks in the top tier of US metros. This suggests that the housing market is slowing down, which can make it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, this may also signal a normalization of the market, rather than a decline in demand.

**Office Economy**

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria has an office economy score that ranks in the 31st percentile, indicating a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies, but may be more suitable for businesses with industrial or logistics-dominated economies.

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area offers businesses a unique combination of high wage growth and relatively low cost of living, which can be beneficial for attracting and retaining talent. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this city is the declining labor force supply, which can create challenges for hiring and expansion. Decision-makers should carefully consider these factors when evaluating Washington-Arlington-Alexandria as a potential business location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #25 OF 50

# San Francisco

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont

**C+**

FAIR

49.7th percentile

Rank 25 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Labor Demand | 25% weight | 56 |
| Unemployment | 20% weight | 42 |
| Wage Growth | 15% weight | 84 |
| Cost of Living | 12% weight | 17 |
| Labor Force YoY | 10% weight | 16 |
| Bldg. Permits | 10% weight | 98 |
| Days on Market | 5% weight | 0 |
| Office Economy | 3% weight | 45 |

## KEY INDICATORS

**UNEMPLOYMENT**
**4.6%**
of civilian labor force

**WAGE GROWTH YOY**
**+5.8%**
avg hourly earnings

**EMPLOYMENT GROWTH**
**+0.6%**
nonfarm payrolls YoY

**LABOR FORCE YOY**
**-2.3%**
civilian labor force growth

**BUILDING PERMITS**
**+118.0%**
residential YoY (3mo avg)

**DAYS ON MARKET**
**37 days**
median, -9.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**STRONG**

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking at the 49.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 5.78%, and its extremely competitive housing market, with homes selling in a median of 37 days, a -9.8% year-over-year change. The combination of these metrics signals a challenging environment for businesses looking to attract and retain talent.

### Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 0.56% year-over-year, with weekly hours deviating 0.469% above the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours are increasing, indicating a healthy labor market. However, the near-median percentile rank of 56th suggests that this growth is not exceptionally strong compared to other metros.

### Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 4.60%, ranking at the 42nd percentile, indicating a near-median level of slack in the labor market. This rate suggests that while the market is not extremely tight, it is still relatively competitive, and businesses may face some challenges in hiring, particularly for specialized roles. The practical implication is that businesses may need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent.

### Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 5.78%, ranking at the 84th percentile, indicating fast and strong wage growth. This implies that employer labor costs are rising, but worker purchasing power is also increasing, which can be beneficial for businesses that rely on local consumer demand. However, this rapid wage growth may also put pressure on businesses to adjust their compensation packages to remain competitive.

### Cost of Living

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has a cost of living percentile rank of 17th, with a PSF of $627/sqft, which is decreasing by 4.3% year-over-year, and an average hourly earnings of $50.39/hr, resulting in a ratio of 12.44. This suggests that the city is relatively expensive, which can make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The low percentile rank indicates that the city is less affordable compared to its peers, which may impact businesses' ability to recruit and retain employees.

### Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is contracting at a rate of -2.31% year-over-year, ranking at the 16th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is shrinking, which can create a structural headwind for hiring and may limit businesses' ability to expand their operations. The implication is that businesses may need to consider alternative locations or strategies to access the talent they need.

**Building Permits**

The year-over-year change in building permits in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 118.02%, ranking at the 98th percentile, indicating a significant expansion in housing supply. This suggests that developer confidence is high, and future housing supply is expected to increase, which can improve affordability and make it easier for businesses to attract and retain talent. However, the current housing market remains extremely competitive, with homes selling quickly.

**Days on Market**

The median days on market in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 37 days, with a year-over-year change of -9.8%, ranking at the 0th percentile. This indicates an extremely competitive market, where homes are selling very quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The low percentile rank suggests that the market is highly competitive, and businesses may need to consider providing relocation assistance or other benefits to help employees navigate the housing market.

**Office Economy**

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has an office economy percentile rank of 45th, with a share of professional and office workers indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This suggests that the city is suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and technical talent, but may not be the best fit for companies that rely heavily on specialized or niche expertise. The city's economy is more geared towards tech, finance, and consulting, but may not be as strong for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area offers businesses a strong and growing economy with a highly skilled workforce, but also presents significant challenges, particularly in terms of housing affordability and labor force growth. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the extremely competitive housing market, which can make it difficult to attract and retain talent, and may require businesses to offer competitive wages and relocation assistance to remain viable.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #26 OF 50

# Birmingham

Birmingham

**C+**

FAIR

49.1th percentile

Rank 26 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Labor Demand | 25% weight | 64 |
| Unemployment | 20% weight | 50 |
| Wage Growth | 15% weight | 2 |
| Cost of Living | 12% weight | 50 |
| Labor Force YoY | 10% weight | 46 |
| Bldg. Permits | 10% weight | 92 |
| Days on Market | 5% weight | 32 |
| Office Economy | 3% weight | 47 |

## KEY INDICATORS

**UNEMPLOYMENT**
**3.4%**
of civilian labor force

**WAGE GROWTH YOY**
**+0.0%**
avg hourly earnings

**EMPLOYMENT GROWTH**
**+0.9%**
nonfarm payrolls YoY

**LABOR FORCE YOY**
**-1.3%**
civilian labor force growth

**BUILDING PERMITS**
**+36.7%**
residential YoY (3mo avg)

**DAYS ON MARKET**
**61 days**
median, +5.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**STRONG**

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Birmingham has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it at the 49.1th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its above-average labor demand, with a composite score at the 64th percentile, and its stagnant wage growth, which ranks at the 2nd percentile. These metrics signal a city with a growing job market but limited upward pressure on wages.

### Labor Demand

Birmingham's employment growth rate is 0.92% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating 0.349% above the city's own 12-month trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours worked are increasing, indicating a strong labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.94 further supports this, ranking above average at the 64th percentile.

### Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Birmingham is 3.40%, ranking near the median at the 50th percentile. This suggests a labor market with some slack, rather than being extremely tight, which means businesses may find it moderately challenging to hire but without extreme wage pressure. The relatively balanced unemployment rate provides a stable environment for hiring.

### Wage Growth

Wage growth in Birmingham is stagnant, with a year-over-year change of only 0.03%, ranking at the 2nd percentile. This indicates very slow wage growth, suggesting that labor costs for employers are not rising quickly, but it also means workers have weak bargaining power and limited purchasing power growth. This stagnant wage environment could attract businesses looking to control labor costs.

### Cost of Living

Birmingham's cost of living is near the median, with a percentile rank of 50th. This suggests that the city is neither particularly affordable nor expensive relative to its peers. For talent attraction, this means that Birmingham may not offer a significant advantage in terms of cost of living without the need for wage premiums to attract workers.

### Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Birmingham is shrinking at a rate of -1.30% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 46th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply signals a potential structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. Businesses may face challenges in finding the right talent due to this shrinking labor pool.

### Building Permits

Building permits in Birmingham are increasing by 36.73% year-over-year, placing the city in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This significant rise in permits indicates that housing supply is expected to expand, which should improve affordability and accommodate workforce growth. This is a positive signal for future workforce attraction and retention.

**Days on Market**

The median days on market for homes in Birmingham is 61 days, with a year-over-year increase of 5.2%, ranking below average at the 32nd percentile. This means the market is relatively fast, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find homes, indicating a competitive housing market.

**Office Economy**

Birmingham's professional and office worker share ranks at the 47th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool in these sectors. The city is suited for businesses that can thrive in a mixed economy but may not be the best fit for those requiring a very deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance hubs.

In conclusion, Birmingham offers a growing job market with above-average labor demand and controlled labor costs due to stagnant wage growth. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the shrinking labor force, which could limit hiring capacity and require strategic talent attraction and retention strategies.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #27 OF 50

# Houston

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands

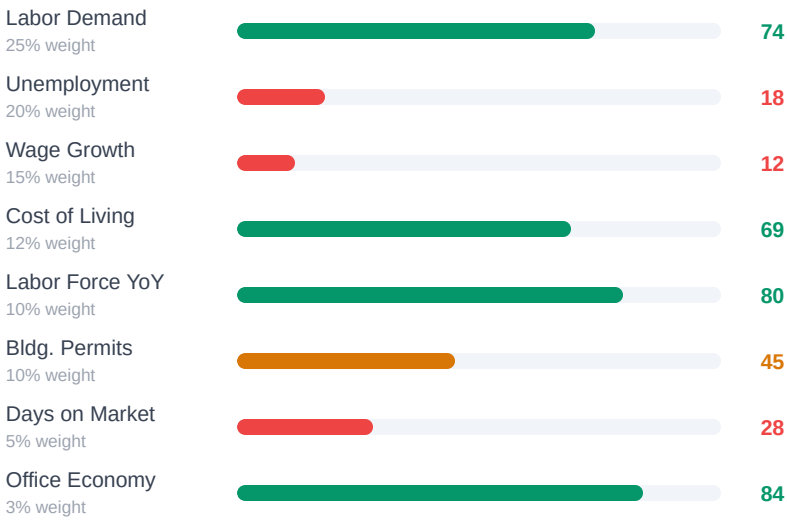
**C+**

FAIR

48.5th percentile

Rank 27 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT<br>**5.0%**<br>of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY<br>**+1.2%**<br>avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH<br>**+1.3%**<br>nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY<br>**+0.6%**<br>civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS<br>**-2.2%**<br>residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET<br>**55 days**<br>median, -1.8% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**STRONG**

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 48.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its above-average labor demand, with a composite score of 6.21 ranking it in the 74th percentile, and its relatively low unemployment rate of 5.00%, which ranks in the 18th percentile. The labor demand and unemployment metrics suggest a city with genuine job growth but also some challenges in hiring due to a relatively tight labor market.

### Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is +1.30% year-over-year, combined with a +0.091% deviation in weekly hours from its own 12-month baseline, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing real job growth, with hours worked above trend, suggesting that businesses are not just maintaining existing staff levels but are actually expanding their workforces. This is a positive indicator for businesses looking to locate in an area with growing economic activity.

### Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is 5.00%, ranking in the 18th percentile, which indicates a relatively tight labor market. This tight market means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as there are fewer unemployed individuals available to fill open positions, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. For a business trying to hire in this market, it may be necessary to offer competitive salaries and benefits to attract top talent.

### Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is +1.21%, ranking in the 12th percentile, which is relatively stagnant. This slow wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also indicates that workers may have weaker bargaining power. For businesses, this could mean a more stable labor cost environment, but it may also limit the attractiveness of the area for workers seeking higher pay.

### Cost of Living

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands has a cost of living score ranking it in the 69th percentile, with a price per square foot of $169 and average hourly earnings of $36.92, resulting in a ratio of 4.58. This suggests that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which could be a significant advantage for talent attraction without needing to offer wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling by -1.7% year-over-year further enhances the city's affordability.

### Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is growing at a rate of +0.64% year-over-year, ranking in the 80th percentile, indicating that the workforce supply is expanding. This expansion in the labor force is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests that there will be a growing pool of potential employees available. This can help mitigate some of the challenges posed by the tight labor market.

**Building Permits**

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is -2.18%, ranking near the median at the 45th percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is not expanding as rapidly as it could be, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. This could be a concern for businesses relying on a mobile workforce or looking to attract talent from other areas.

**Days on Market**

The current median days on market for homes in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is 55 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -1.8%, ranking in the 28th percentile. This relatively fast pace of home sales indicates a competitive market, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the decrease in days on market suggests some normalization in the housing market.

**Office Economy**

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share composite ranking it in the 84th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that rely on specialized knowledge-economy talent. Conversely, it may be less ideal for industries dominated by industrial or logistics roles.

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area offers businesses a unique combination of growing labor demand and an expanding workforce, making it an attractive location for companies looking to tap into a diverse and growing talent pool. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the potential for future affordability issues due to the decline in residential building permits, which could impact the city's ability to accommodate a growing workforce and attract new talent without significant wage premiums.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #28 OF 50

# Oklahoma City

Oklahoma City

**C+**

FAIR

46.7th percentile

Rank 28 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Labor Demand | 25% weight | 42 |
| Unemployment | 20% weight | 40 |
| Wage Growth | 15% weight | 58 |
| Cost of Living | 12% weight | 56 |
| Labor Force YoY | 10% weight | 34 |
| Bldg. Permits | 10% weight | 61 |
| Days on Market | 5% weight | 58 |
| Office Economy | 3% weight | 10 |

## KEY INDICATORS

**UNEMPLOYMENT**
**3.9%**
of civilian labor force

**WAGE GROWTH YOY**
**+4.2%**
avg hourly earnings

**EMPLOYMENT GROWTH**
**+0.7%**
nonfarm payrolls YoY

**LABOR FORCE YOY**
**-1.6%**
civilian labor force growth

**BUILDING PERMITS**
**+14.2%**
residential YoY (3mo avg)

**DAYS ON MARKET**
**57 days**
median, +9.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**GROWING**

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Oklahoma City has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 46.7th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its near-median labor demand composite score of 5.17 and its below-average labor force growth rate of -1.65% YoY. These metrics suggest a mixed economic environment, with some indicators pointing to stability and others to potential challenges.

**Labor Demand**

Oklahoma City's employment growth rate is +0.74% YoY, while weekly hours are -0.163% below trend, resulting in a near-median labor demand composite score. This combination signals a moderate expansion of jobs, but with hours worked slightly below trend, indicating some slack in the labor market. The city is not experiencing a strong genuine demand expansion, but rather a gradual growth with some room for additional hiring.

**Unemployment**

The unemployment rate in Oklahoma City is 3.90%, ranking near the median at the 40th percentile. This rate indicates a relatively balanced labor market, neither extremely tight nor overly slack. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate means that finding talent may not be excessively difficult, but it also may not be particularly easy, with some wage pressure possible.

**Wage Growth**

Wage growth in Oklahoma City is +4.20% YoY, which is near the median at the 58th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely rapidly. Workers in the city are experiencing an increase in purchasing power, which can contribute to local consumer demand, benefiting businesses that rely on a strong local economy.

**Cost of Living**

Oklahoma City has a cost of living score ranking it near the median at the 56th percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of $171/sqft to $34.33/hr, or 4.98. The city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage without needing significant wage premiums. This affordability can help businesses in attracting and retaining workers without incurring high labor costs.

**Labor Force Growth**

The civilian labor force in Oklahoma City is shrinking at a rate of -1.65% YoY, ranking below average at the 34th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. Businesses may face challenges in finding the talent they need, potentially leading to increased competition for workers and upward pressure on wages.

**Building Permits**

Residential building permits in Oklahoma City are increasing by +14.19% YoY, ranking above average at the 61st percentile. This expansion in housing supply is a positive sign for future affordability and workforce accommodation, indicating that the city is likely to remain attractive to workers and businesses alike. The growing housing supply can help mitigate potential labor market constraints.

**Days on Market**

The median days on market for homes in Oklahoma City is 57 days, with a +9.6% YoY increase, ranking near the median at the 58th percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced housing market, neither extremely competitive nor overly slow. For workers relocating to the city, the housing market is accessible, but not excessively fast-paced, allowing for a reasonable timeframe to find suitable housing.

**Office Economy**

Oklahoma City's professional and office worker share ranks in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. The city is less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more appropriate for industries with different workforce requirements, such as logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, Oklahoma City offers a mixed economic environment with both positive and negative factors for businesses to consider. The city's relatively affordable cost of living and expanding housing supply are advantages, but the shrinking labor force and limited professional talent pool pose significant risks. Decision-makers should carefully weigh these factors, particularly the labor market constraints, when evaluating Oklahoma City as a potential business location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #29 OF 50

# Boston

Boston-Cambridge-Newton

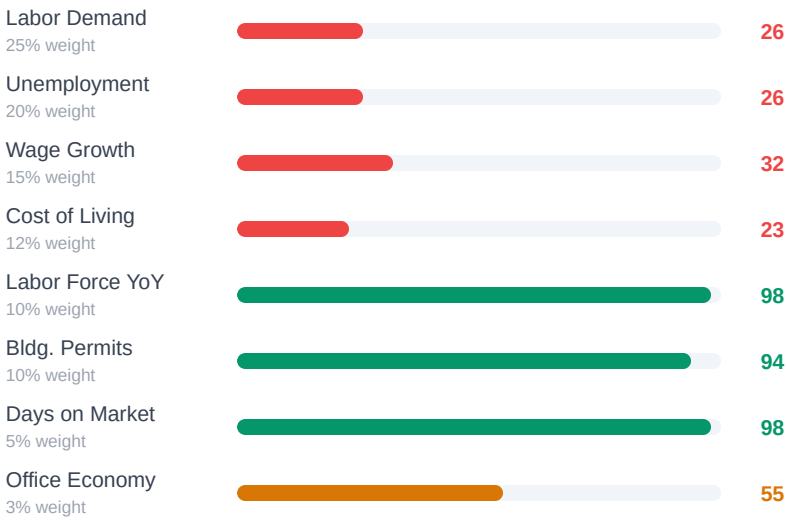
**C+**

FAIR

45.0th percentile

Rank 29 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT **3.9%** of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY **+2.9%** avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.1%** nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY **+2.9%** civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS **+72.3%** residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET **43 days** median, +19.4% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**WEAK**

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it at the 45.0th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor force growth of 2.87% YoY and its high building permits growth of 72.27% YoY, indicating a expanding workforce and housing supply. The labor demand composite score of 4.13, however, suggests a more nuanced economic picture.

**Labor Demand**

The employment growth rate of -0.12% YoY and weekly hours deviation of -0.351% from the city's own trend signal a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and hours worked. This combination suggests that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion, but rather a slowdown in economic activity. The labor demand composite score of 4.13, ranking at the 26th percentile, further supports this assessment.

**Unemployment**

The unemployment rate of 3.90% is relatively low, ranking at the 26th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with some slack. For a business trying to hire in this city, this means that it may be moderately challenging to find qualified candidates, and wage pressure may be present. However, the unemployment rate is not extremely low, suggesting that there is still some availability of labor.

**Wage Growth**

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 2.93% is moderate, ranking at the 32nd percentile, indicating that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely quickly. This moderate wage growth suggests that worker purchasing power is increasing, but not at a rapid pace. For employers, this means that labor costs are manageable, but may still be a consideration in hiring and compensation decisions.

**Cost of Living**

The cost of living in Boston-Cambridge-Newton, with a PSF of $459/sqft and an earnings ratio of 10.02, ranks at the 23rd percentile, indicating that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is falling by 3.0% YoY is a positive sign, but the overall affordability score suggests that the city may not have a significant talent attraction advantage without wage premiums. This may make it challenging for businesses to attract and retain talent without offering competitive compensation packages.

**Labor Force Growth**

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 2.87% YoY, ranking at the 98th percentile, indicating that the workforce supply is expanding rapidly. This strong labor force growth suggests that the city has a significant hiring capacity, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to expand their workforce. The growing labor force also suggests that the city is likely to have a diverse and skilled talent pool.

**Building Permits**

The year-over-year change in building permits is 72.27%, ranking at the 94th percentile, indicating that housing supply is expanding rapidly. This suggests that the city is likely to experience improving affordability and a more accommodating workforce in the future. The strong growth in building permits is a positive sign for businesses looking to relocate or expand in the city, as it suggests that the city is investing in its infrastructure and housing stock.

**Days on Market**

The current median days on market is 43 days, with a year-over-year increase of 19.4%, ranking at the 98th percentile, indicating a slower market. For a worker relocating to this city, this means that the housing market is relatively accessible, with homes taking longer to sell. This slower market may give relocating workers more time to find a suitable home, making the city a more attractive location for talent.

**Office Economy**

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors is 2.71, ranking at the 55th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This suggests that the city is suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but may not be as attractive for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses. The city's office economy is relatively balanced, making it a viable location for a variety of businesses.

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a growing labor force and expanding housing supply, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand their workforce. However, the city's relatively high cost of living and moderate wage growth may pose challenges for businesses looking to attract and retain talent without offering competitive compensation packages.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #30 OF 50

# Providence

Providence-Warwick

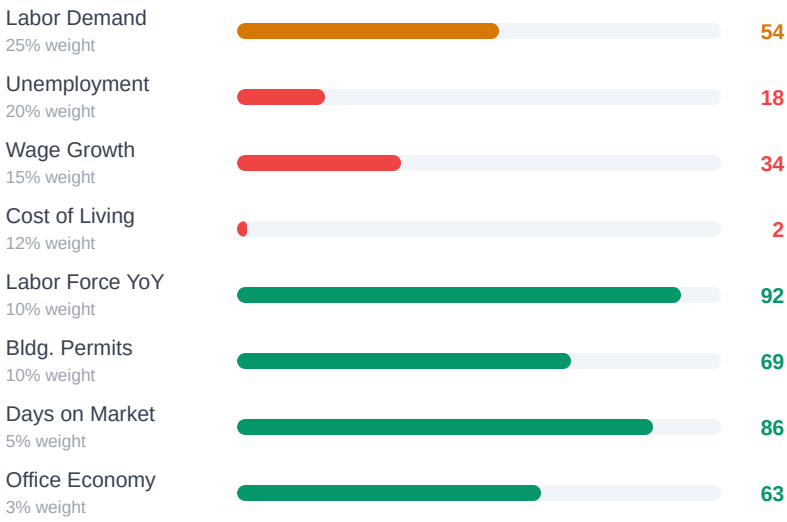
**C+**

FAIR

44.8th percentile

Rank 30 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT **4.3%** of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY **+3.1%** avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.6%** nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY **+1.7%** civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS **+18.4%** residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET **39 days** median, +8.3% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**STRONG**

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Providence-Warwick metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 44.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 4.30% and its high labor force growth rate of +1.69% YoY, indicating a tight labor market with an expanding workforce. The labor demand composite score of 5.47, near the median, suggests a moderate level of job growth and hours worked.

### Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.60% YoY and weekly hours deviation of +0.326% from the city's own trend signal a genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This combination indicates that the labor market is experiencing an increase in jobs and working hours, suggesting a healthy demand for labor. The near-median percentile rank of 54th suggests that this growth is moderate compared to other cities.

### Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.30% is relatively low, ranking in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers have more bargaining power.

### Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +3.09% is below average, ranking at the 34th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in many other cities, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not as quickly as in other areas. The moderate wage growth may help businesses manage labor costs while still providing workers with some increase in earnings.

### Cost of Living

The cost of living in Providence-Warwick is relatively expensive, with a percentile rank of 2, indicating that it is one of the least affordable cities. The PSF of $360/sqft and average hourly earnings of $36.41/hr result in a ratio of 9.89, which is high compared to other cities. This means that the city may struggle to attract talent without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

### Labor Force Growth

The labor force growth rate of +1.69% YoY is in the top tier, ranking at the 92nd percentile, indicating that the workforce supply is expanding rapidly. This suggests that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, which can help businesses meet their hiring needs. The expanding labor force also indicates a healthy and dynamic labor market.

**Building Permits**

The year-over-year change in building permits is +18.42%, ranking above average at the 69th percentile, indicating that housing supply is expanding. This suggests that the city is experiencing an increase in new housing construction, which can help improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. The rising permits also signal that developers are confident in the city's future growth prospects.

**Days on Market**

The current median days on market is 39 days, with a year-over-year increase of +8.3%, ranking in the top tier at the 86th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. The rising days on market also suggest a healthy normalization of the housing market.

**Office Economy**

The share of professional and office workers is 2.88, ranking above average at the 63rd percentile, indicating a deep talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but may be less suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses. The city's professional talent pool is a significant advantage for businesses looking to locate or expand in the area.

The Providence-Warwick metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, moderate labor demand, and an expanding workforce, making it an attractive location for companies looking to tap into a growing talent pool. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses is the high cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract and retain talent, potentially increasing labor costs and affecting profitability.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #31 OF 50

# Phoenix

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler

**C+**

FAIR

44.6th percentile

Rank 31 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Labor Demand | 25% weight | 76 |
| Unemployment | 20% weight | 8 |
| Wage Growth | 15% weight | 40 |
| Cost of Living | 12% weight | 54 |
| Labor Force YoY | 10% weight | 8 |
| Bldg. Permits | 10% weight | 57 |
| Days on Market | 5% weight | 52 |
| Office Economy | 3% weight | 80 |

## KEY INDICATORS

**UNEMPLOYMENT**
**4.9%**
of civilian labor force

**WAGE GROWTH YOY**
**+3.3%**
avg hourly earnings

**EMPLOYMENT GROWTH**
**+0.9%**
nonfarm payrolls YoY

**LABOR FORCE YOY**
**-2.9%**
civilian labor force growth

**BUILDING PERMITS**
**+11.0%**
residential YoY (3mo avg)

**DAYS ON MARKET**
**62 days**
median, -4.6% YoY

**LABOR MARKET SIGNAL**

**STRONG**

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 44.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, with a composite score in the 76th percentile, and its labor force growth, which is in the bottom tier at 8th percentile, indicating a shrinking labor pool. The labor demand metrics, including employment growth and weekly hours, signal genuine demand expansion.

### Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is +0.91% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating +0.771% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, a positive sign for businesses looking to expand. The labor demand composite score of 6.34 further reinforces this trend, ranking in the 76th percentile.

### Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 4.90%, ranking in the bottom tier at 8th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face challenges finding available workers, leading to potential wage pressure. With such a low unemployment rate, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

### Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is +3.28%, ranking near the median at 40th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate of wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, and worker purchasing power is increasing. As a result, businesses may need to balance their labor costs with the benefits of a growing workforce.

### Cost of Living

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler has a cost of living percentile rank of 54th, with a PSF of $264/sqft and average hourly earnings of $38.11/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.93. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, with a falling PSF (-1.9% YoY) contributing to its affordability. This affordability advantage can help attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums.

### Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is shrinking at a rate of -2.93% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at 8th percentile. This contraction in labor supply poses a significant challenge for businesses looking to hire, as it may limit their ability to find qualified workers. The shrinking labor pool is a structural headwind for hiring in this city.

### Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is increasing by +10.99% year-over-year, ranking near the median at 57th percentile. This expansion in housing supply is a positive sign for future affordability and workforce accommodation, as it suggests that the city is investing in its infrastructure to support growing demand.

**Days on Market**

The current median days on market in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 62 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -4.6%. This indicates a relatively fast-moving market, which can make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the decreasing days on market suggests that the market is becoming more competitive, which could benefit businesses looking to attract talent.

**Office Economy**

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy percentile rank of 80th. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which rely on specialized knowledge workers. However, it may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area offers businesses a unique combination of genuine labor demand expansion and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force, which poses significant challenges for hiring and talent attraction. Despite this, the city's investment in housing supply and its deep professional talent pool make it an attractive location for certain types of businesses.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #32 OF 50

# Portland

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro

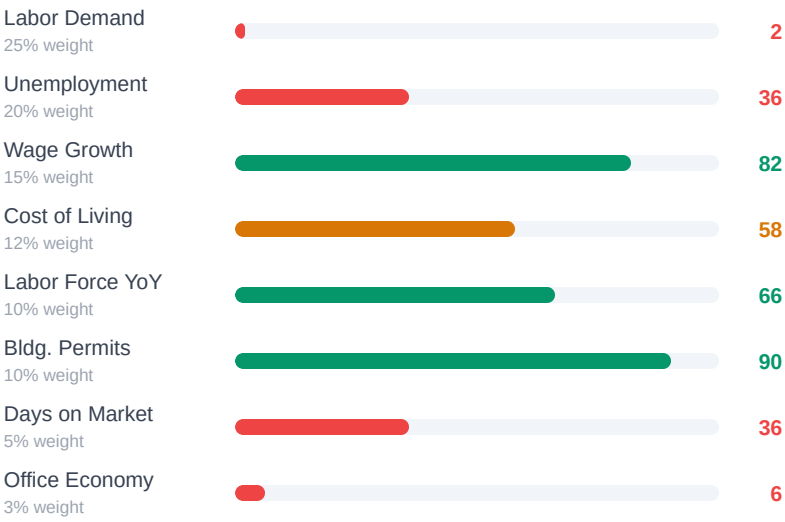
**C+**

FAIR

44.6th percentile

Rank 32 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT<br>**4.9%**<br>of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY<br>**+5.7%**<br>avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH<br>**-1.5%**<br>nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY<br>**+0.1%**<br>civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS<br>**+32.3%**<br>residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET<br>**66 days**<br>median, 0.0% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**SQUEEZE**

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 44.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand, with a labor demand composite score in the bottom tier at 2nd percentile, and strong wage growth, at 82nd percentile with a 5.68% year-over-year increase. The combination of these metrics suggests a complex economic environment.

### Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is -1.52% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.368%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and hours worked, which may lead to a survivor squeeze where remaining workers absorb the workload of eliminated roles.

### Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 4.90%, ranking it at the 36th percentile, indicating a below-average but not extremely tight labor market. This suggests that while there is some slack in the market, hiring may still be moderately challenging, and businesses may face some wage pressure.

### Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 5.68%, placing it in the top tier at the 82nd percentile. This fast wage growth indicates rising labor costs for employers but also strong purchasing power for workers, which can be beneficial for businesses relying on local consumer demand.

### Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $303/sqft to $42.52/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.13, and a percentile rank of 58th, Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is near the median in terms of affordability. The PSF is falling by -2.3% year-over-year, which is a positive sign for affordability. This suggests that the city offers a moderate talent attraction advantage without requiring significant wage premiums.

### Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is growing at a rate of +0.05% year-over-year, ranking it above average at the 66th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is slowly expanding, which is a positive sign for hiring capacity and suggests that businesses may find a gradually increasing pool of potential employees.

### Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro has increased by 32.26% year-over-year, placing it in the top tier at the 90th percentile. This significant increase in building permits signals that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate workforce growth in the future.

**Days on Market**

The current median days on market for homes in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 66 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%, ranking it below average at the 36th percentile. This suggests a moderately competitive market for relocating workers, as homes are selling relatively quickly, which may pose some challenges for businesses trying to attract talent from other areas.

**Office Economy**

With an office/professional worker share composite score of 0.69, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile, Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro has a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This indicates that the city is less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more appropriate for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth and expanding housing supply, which can support workforce attraction and retention. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's weak labor demand, which may signal underlying economic challenges and impact the availability of skilled workers, making it essential to carefully consider these factors in location decisions.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #33 OF 50

# San Jose

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara

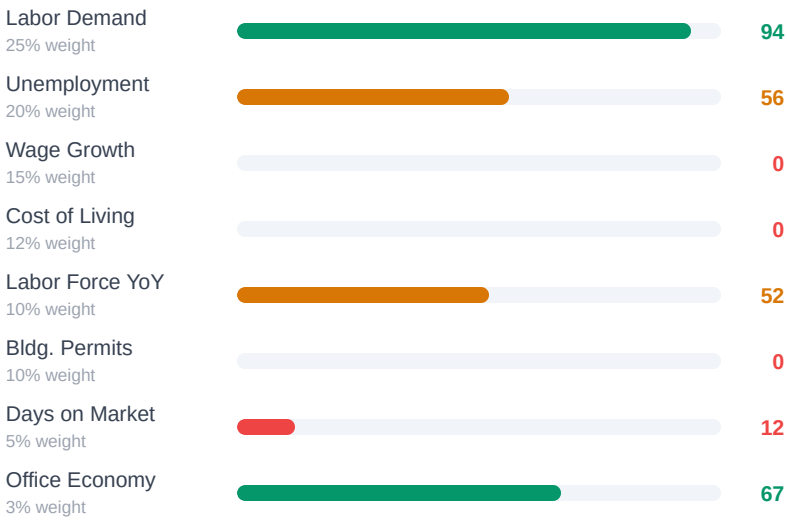
**C**

VERY POOR

42.5th percentile

Rank 33 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT **4.3%** of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY **-0.8%** avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.6%** nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY **-1.1%** civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS **-43.7%** residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET **35 days** median, -2.8% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**STRONG**

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 42.5th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and deep office economy. The city's economic character is defined by its top-tier labor demand composite score of 7.81 and its bottom-tier wage growth rate of -0.78%. These metrics signal a complex economic environment with both opportunities and challenges.

### Labor Demand

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has an employment growth rate of +1.59% and a weekly hours deviation of +1.289% from its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a strong increase in jobs and hours worked, suggesting a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 7.81, ranking in the 94th percentile, further reinforces this assessment.

### Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is 4.30%, ranking in the 56th percentile, indicating a near-median level of unemployment. This suggests that the job market is relatively balanced, neither extremely tight nor overly slack. For a business trying to hire in this city, this means that while it may not be extremely difficult to find talent, it also won't be unusually easy, and wages may be subject to moderate pressure.

### Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is -0.78%, ranking in the 0th percentile, indicating stagnant or even declining wages. This suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also means that worker purchasing power is not increasing. This could have implications for businesses relying on local consumer demand.

### Cost of Living

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has a cost of living ratio of $827/sqft to $54.03/hr, with a year-over-year increase of 0.5% in PSF, ranking in the 0th percentile for affordability. This means that the city is extremely expensive relative to peers, making it challenging to attract talent without offering significant wage premiums. The high cost of living could be a major constraint for businesses looking to relocate or expand in this area.

### Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is growing at a rate of -1.08% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor pool. This suggests that the supply of potential workers is shrinking, which could create structural headwinds for hiring

and business expansion in the area.

**Building Permits**

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is -43.67%, indicating a sharp decline in housing supply expansion. This signals that the city may be heading towards a supply squeeze, which could further exacerbate affordability issues and make it even more challenging for workers to relocate to the area.

**Days on Market**

The median days on market for homes in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is 35 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -2.8%, ranking in the 12th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced housing market, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing. However, the slight decrease in days on market might suggest a minor normalization in the market.

**Office Economy**

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has an above-average share of professional and office workers, ranking in the 67th percentile. This suggests a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions, making the city an attractive location for businesses in these sectors. However, it may be less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented economies.

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area offers a unique combination of strong labor demand and a deep office economy, making it an attractive location for certain types of businesses. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the extremely high cost of living, which could significantly impact talent attraction and retention, as well as the overall affordability of the area for both businesses and their employees.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #34 OF 50

# Virginia Beach

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk

**C**

VERY POOR

41.2th percentile

Rank 34 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Labor Demand | 25% weight | 14 |
| Unemployment | 20% weight | 66 |
| Wage Growth | 15% weight | 78 |
| Cost of Living | 12% weight | 52 |
| Labor Force YoY | 10% weight | 12 |
| Bldg. Permits | 10% weight | 29 |
| Days on Market | 5% weight | 36 |
| Office Economy | 3% weight | 24 |

## KEY INDICATORS

**UNEMPLOYMENT**
**3.7%**
of civilian labor force

**WAGE GROWTH YOY**
**+5.5%**
avg hourly earnings

**EMPLOYMENT GROWTH**
**-0.6%**
nonfarm payrolls YoY

**LABOR FORCE YOY**
**-2.6%**
civilian labor force growth

**BUILDING PERMITS**
**-10.4%**
residential YoY (3mo avg)

**DAYS ON MARKET**
**44 days**
median, 0.0% YoY

### LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**SQUEEZE**

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 41.2th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its low labor demand and labor force growth. The labor demand composite score of 3.36, combining a -0.55% employment growth rate and a +0.174% weekly hours deviation, and the -2.61% labor force growth rate are the two metrics that most define this city's current economic character, signaling a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate. With a labor demand score in the bottom tier, at the 14th percentile, this city's economic landscape is marked by contraction.

**Labor Demand**

The employment growth rate of -0.55% and weekly hours deviation of +0.174% indicate a scenario where hours are slightly above trend during a period of job losses, suggesting a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand rather than genuine demand expansion. The low labor demand composite score of 3.36 further emphasizes the challenges in this market.

**Unemployment**

The unemployment rate of 3.70% places this city above average, at the 66th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market with some slack. For a business trying to hire in this market, the implication is that while it may be slightly easier to find talent than in extremely tight markets, there is still enough competition to potentially drive up wages. However, the relatively low unemployment rate does not fully offset the concerns raised by other metrics.

**Wage Growth**

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +5.51% is above average, ranking at the 78th percentile, indicating fast wage growth. This implies rising labor costs for employers but also good worker purchasing power, which can be beneficial for consumer demand. The fast wage growth is a positive aspect of this city's economy, suggesting a strong labor market in terms of compensation.

**Cost of Living**

With a cost of living ratio of $223/sqft to $35.71/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.24, and a percentile rank of 52, this city is near the median in terms of affordability. The PSF is increasing at a rate of +2.8% YoY, which does not help affordability. This means that while the city is not extremely expensive, it does not offer a significant talent attraction advantage without wage premiums, as its affordability is average compared to peers.

**Labor Force Growth**

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -2.61% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, making it challenging for businesses to find and recruit talent. The implication for hiring capacity is negative, suggesting that businesses may face difficulties in expanding their workforce.

**Building Permits**

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -10.45%, indicating a tightening in housing supply. This signals potential future affordability issues and challenges for workforce accommodation, as a lack of new housing developments can lead to increased competition for existing homes and higher prices. The decrease in building permits is a concern for future workforce attraction and retention.

**Days on Market**

The current median days on market is 44 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%, indicating a stable but relatively slow market. For a worker relocating to this city, the housing market is neither extremely competitive nor very accessible, offering a moderate environment for home buying. The stable days on market suggest a balanced market, but the context of other economic indicators suggests caution.

**Office Economy**

With an office/professional worker share composite score placing it at the 24th percentile, this city has a below-average depth of professional talent pool. This makes it less suited for businesses requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, consulting, or HQ decisions, but potentially more suitable for industries with different workforce requirements.

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area presents a mixed bag for businesses considering relocation or expansion, with fast wage growth and a relatively tight labor market being positives, but labor demand contraction, shrinking labor force, and tightening housing supply being significant negatives. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the challenging labor market conditions, including low labor demand and a contracting labor force, which could hinder business growth and expansion plans. Overall, while there are some positive aspects, the economic character of this city is defined by its labor market challenges.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #35 OF 50

# New York

New York Newark-Jersey City

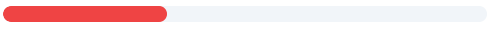
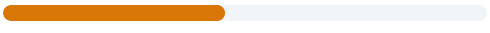
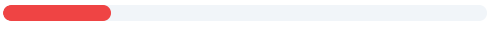
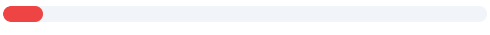
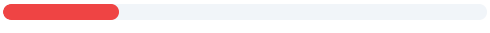
**C**

VERY POOR

39.7th percentile

Rank 35 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Labor Demand<br>25% weight |  | 34 |
| Unemployment<br>20% weight |  | 46 |
| Wage Growth<br>15% weight |  | 22 |
| Cost of Living<br>12% weight |  | 8 |
| Labor Force YoY<br>10% weight |  | 64 |
| Bldg. Permits<br>10% weight |  | 82 |
| Days on Market<br>5% weight |  | 24 |
| Office Economy<br>3% weight |  | 65 |

## KEY INDICATORS

**UNEMPLOYMENT**
**4.7%**
of civilian labor force

**WAGE GROWTH YOY**
**+1.9%**
avg hourly earnings

**EMPLOYMENT GROWTH**
**+0.5%**
nonfarm payrolls YoY

**LABOR FORCE YOY**
**-0.1%**
civilian labor force growth

**BUILDING PERMITS**
**+27.9%**
residential YoY (3mo avg)

**DAYS ON MARKET**
**56 days**
median, -3.5% YoY

### LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**GROWING**

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 39.7th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its below-average labor demand and high cost of living. The labor demand composite score of 4.80, which combines a +0.50% employment growth rate and a -0.202% weekly hours deviation from trend, signals a contraction in genuine demand expansion. The cost of living, with a PSF of $494/sqft and an earnings ratio of 12.08, ranks in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, indicating a highly expensive environment.

### Labor Demand

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has an employment growth rate of +0.50% and a weekly hours deviation of -0.202% from its own trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.80. This combination signals a contraction in genuine demand expansion, as the hours worked are below trend despite some job growth. This suggests that the labor market is not as strong as the employment growth rate alone might indicate.

### Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is 4.70%, ranking near the median at the 46th percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced labor market, neither too tight nor too slack. For a business trying to hire in this market, the moderate unemployment rate suggests that finding qualified candidates may be manageable, but may not be as easy as in areas with higher unemployment rates.

### Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is +1.91%, ranking below average at the 22nd percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not as quickly as in other metros. For workers, this means that purchasing power is increasing, but not at a rapid pace.

### Cost of Living

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has a cost of living ratio of 12.08, with a PSF of $494/sqft and earnings of $40.91/hr, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile. This indicates that the city is highly expensive relative to peers, making it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling by -0.8% YoY slightly mitigates this, but the overall affordability remains a concern.

### Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is growing at a rate of -0.15% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 64th percentile. Despite the negative growth rate, the labor force supply is still relatively stable, suggesting that hiring capacity is not severely constrained. However, the slight contraction in labor force growth may signal a potential structural headwind for future hiring.

**Building Permits**

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has seen a +27.93% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, ranking in the top tier at the 82nd percentile. This significant increase in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which may improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce in the future.

**Days on Market**

The median days on market in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is 56 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -3.5%. This relatively fast market, ranking below average at the 24th percentile, indicates that homes are selling quickly, making it competitive for relocating workers to find housing.

**Office Economy**

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share of 2.92, ranking above average at the 65th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less ideal for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area offers a business a highly skilled and professional workforce, with a growing housing supply that may improve affordability in the future. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the high cost of living, which may require significant wage premiums to attract and retain talent, potentially increasing labor costs and affecting the bottom line.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #36 OF 50

# Minneapolis

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington

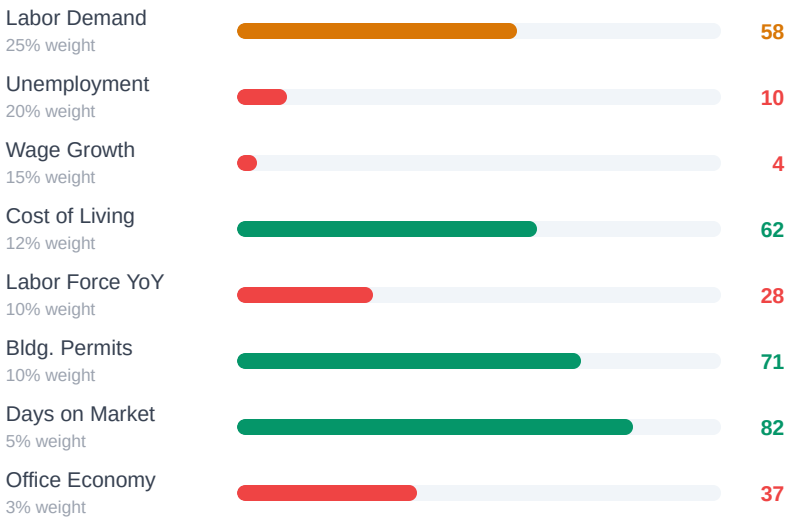
**C**

VERY POOR

39.7th percentile

Rank 36 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT **4.7%** of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY **+0.3%** avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.4%** nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY **-1.8%** civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS **+18.4%** residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET **42 days** median, +7.7% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**GROWING**

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 39.7th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 5.57. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 4.70% and stagnant wage growth of +0.27% YoY. The combination of these metrics suggests a tight labor market with limited room for wage growth.

### Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is +1.39% YoY, while weekly hours are -0.671% below trend. This combination signals a moderate expansion in job numbers, but with hours worked below the 12-month baseline, indicating some level of survivor squeeze where remaining workers may be absorbing the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 5.57 is near the median, ranking 58th percentile.

### Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 4.70%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. This indicates a tight labor market with limited slack, making it harder for businesses to hire and potentially leading to upward wage pressure. Businesses looking to hire in this market may face challenges in finding available talent.

### Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is +0.27%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. This stagnant wage growth suggests a flat cost environment for employers, but weak bargaining power for workers. As a result, worker purchasing power may not be increasing significantly, which could impact local consumer demand.

### Cost of Living

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington has a cost of living score with a PSF of $206/sqft, which is decreasing by -2.4% YoY, and an average hourly earnings of $40.75/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.06. With a percentile rank of 62, the city is relatively more affordable compared to its peers. This affordability could be a talent attraction advantage, as workers may not require significant wage premiums to maintain their standard of living.

### Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is contracting at a rate of -1.77% YoY, ranking below average at the 28th percentile. This decline in labor force supply indicates a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is shrinking. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract talent from other areas or invest in workforce development.

### Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington has increased by +18.45% YoY, ranking above average at the 71st percentile. This expansion in housing supply suggests that developer confidence is strong, and future affordability may improve. As a result, the city may become more attractive for relocating workers and businesses looking for a stable and growing workforce.

**Days on Market**

The median days on market for homes in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is currently 42 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.7%. With a percentile rank of 82, the market is relatively slow, indicating a more accessible and less competitive environment for workers relocating to the city. This could be beneficial for businesses looking to attract talent, as relocating workers may find it easier to find and purchase homes.

**Office Economy**

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington has an office economy percentile rank of 37, indicating a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This city is less suited for businesses requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and an expanding housing supply, which could attract talent and support workforce growth. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tight labor market with limited room for wage growth, making it challenging to hire and retain talent in this region.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #37 OF 50

# Sacramento

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom

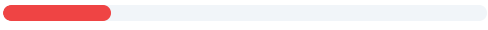
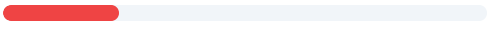
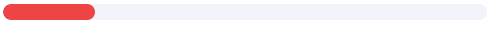
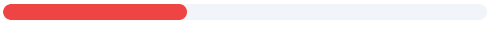
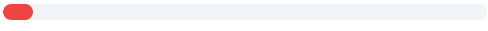
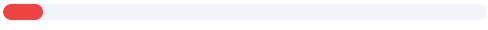
**C**

VERY POOR

38.9th percentile

Rank 37 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Labor Demand (25% weight) |  | 62 |
| Unemployment (20% weight) |  | 22 |
| Wage Growth (15% weight) |  | 24 |
| Cost of Living (12% weight) |  | 19 |
| Labor Force YoY (10% weight) |  | 38 |
| Bldg. Permits (10% weight) |  | 88 |
| Days on Market (5% weight) |  | 6 |
| Office Economy (3% weight) |  | 8 |

## KEY INDICATORS

**UNEMPLOYMENT**
5.2%
of civilian labor force

**WAGE GROWTH YOY**
+2.0%
avg hourly earnings

**EMPLOYMENT GROWTH**
+0.8%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

**LABOR FORCE YOY**
-1.5%
civilian labor force growth

**BUILDING PERMITS**
+30.2%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

**DAYS ON MARKET**
51 days
median, -8.9% YoY

### LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**STRONG**

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 38.9th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its labor demand and cost of living metrics. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.87, combining a 0.76% employment growth rate and a 0.508% weekly hours deviation above its own trend, suggests genuine demand expansion. Additionally, the cost of living, with a PSF of $340/sqft and an hourly wage of $38.44, resulting in a ratio of 8.84, places the city in the bottom tier for affordability, ranking 19th percentile.

**Labor Demand**

The employment growth rate of 0.76% and weekly hours deviation of 0.508% above trend indicate genuine demand expansion in the Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area. This combination signals that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and hours worked, suggesting a strong labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.87, ranking in the 62nd percentile, further supports this assessment.

**Unemployment**

The unemployment rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom stands at 5.20%, ranking in the 22nd percentile, indicating a market with some slack. This rate suggests that while it may not be extremely difficult to hire, there is still a notable pool of unemployed individuals seeking work. For businesses, this means there is a moderate level of competition for talent, but not to the extent seen in tighter labor markets.

**Wage Growth**

The year-over-year wage growth in the metro area is 2.02%, ranking in the 24th percentile, which is considered below average. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are increasing, but at a slower pace than in many other cities. Consequently, worker purchasing power is also growing, albeit slowly.

**Cost of Living**

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom has a cost of living percentile rank of 19th, indicating it is one of the more expensive cities relative to its peers. With a PSF of $340/sqft and hourly wages of $38.44, the city's high cost of living may deter talent without offering wage premiums, making it challenging for businesses to attract and retain employees without significant compensation adjustments.

**Labor Force Growth**

The civilian labor force in the Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area is contracting at a rate of -1.54% year-over-year, ranking in the 38th percentile. This decline in labor force supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential employees is shrinking. Businesses may face increasing difficulty in finding qualified candidates due to this contraction.

**Building Permits**

The city has seen a 30.25% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, placing it in the top tier with an 88th percentile rank. This significant rise in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which could lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce in the future.

**Days on Market**

Homes in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom are currently selling after a median of 51 days on the market, with a year-over-year decrease of 8.9%. This relatively fast pace, ranking in the 6th percentile, indicates a competitive market where homes sell quickly, potentially making it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing.

**Office Economy**

The share of professional and office sector jobs in the metro area is 0.76, ranking in the 8th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, and may be more accommodating to industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area offers a mix of genuine labor demand expansion and challenges such as a high cost of living and a contracting labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the affordability of housing and the potential difficulty in attracting talent without offering significant wage premiums, which could offset the benefits of the city's growing labor demand and expanding housing supply.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #38 OF 50

# San Diego

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad

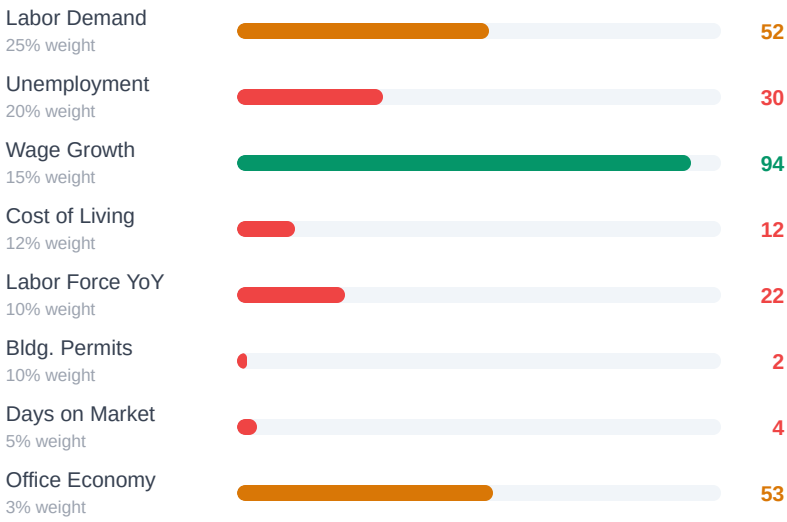
**C**

VERY POOR

38.8th percentile

Rank 38 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT **4.9%** of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY **+7.5%** avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.7%** nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY **-2.1%** civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS **-36.4%** residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET **46 days** median, -6.1% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**STRONG**

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 38.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score defined largely by its high wage growth and low affordability. The city's economic character is most notably marked by a 94th percentile wage growth rate of +7.50% year-over-year and a cost of living ratio of $587/sqft to $44.28/hr, ranking in the 12th percentile for affordability. These metrics suggest a challenging environment for businesses looking to manage labor costs while attracting talent.

**Labor Demand**

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area has an employment growth rate of +0.70% year-over-year and weekly hours deviation of +0.152% from its own trend, combining for a labor demand composite score in the 52nd percentile. This signals a genuine demand expansion, albeit at a moderate pace. The combination of job growth and hours above trend indicates that the labor market is experiencing genuine demand, rather than a survivor squeeze where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles.

**Unemployment**

The unemployment rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad stands at 4.90%, ranking in the 30th percentile, indicating a market with some slack but not overly loose. This rate suggests that while it may not be extremely difficult to hire, there is still competition for talent, and businesses may face some wage pressure. However, the market is not as tight as in other metros, providing a relatively more accessible hiring environment.

**Wage Growth**

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of +7.50%, San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad ranks in the 94th percentile, indicating fast and significant wage increases. This rapid wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers but also strong purchasing power for workers. Businesses should anticipate higher compensation packages to attract and retain talent in this market.

**Cost of Living**

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has a cost of living ratio of $587/sqft to $44.28/hr, ranking in the 12th percentile for affordability, making it one of the more expensive cities relative to peers. The PSF has decreased by -3.5% year-over-year, but the city remains expensive. This low affordability score means that attracting talent without offering significant wage premiums will be challenging, as the high cost of living may deter potential employees.

**Labor Force Growth**

The civilian labor force in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has contracted by -2.06% year-over-year, ranking in the 22nd percentile. This negative growth rate indicates that the labor force supply is shrinking, posing a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion.

Companies looking to grow their workforce may face challenges in finding sufficient talent.

**Building Permits**

Residential building permits in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad have decreased by -36.38% year-over-year, ranking in the 2nd percentile. This sharp decline signals a tightening housing supply, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. The decrease in building permits suggests that developer confidence is low, potentially exacerbating housing supply constraints.

**Days on Market**

The median days on market for homes in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 46 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -6.1%, ranking in the 4th percentile. This fast-paced market indicates that homes are selling quickly, making it competitive and potentially challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The low days on market suggests a hot housing market, which could be a barrier for talent relocation.

**Office Economy**

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has an office and professional worker share ranked in the 53rd percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. However, it is less suited for industries requiring large industrial or logistics workforces. The city's professional talent pool is average compared to its peers, suggesting that businesses in knowledge-economy sectors may find sufficient talent, but those in other sectors may face more challenges.

In conclusion, San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad offers a high-wage growth environment that can attract highly skilled talent, but it also presents significant challenges, including a very high cost of living and a shrinking labor force. The single biggest risk for businesses considering this location is the affordability and housing supply constraints, which could limit their ability to attract and retain talent without offering substantial compensation packages.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #39 OF 50

# Milwaukee

Milwaukee-Waukesha

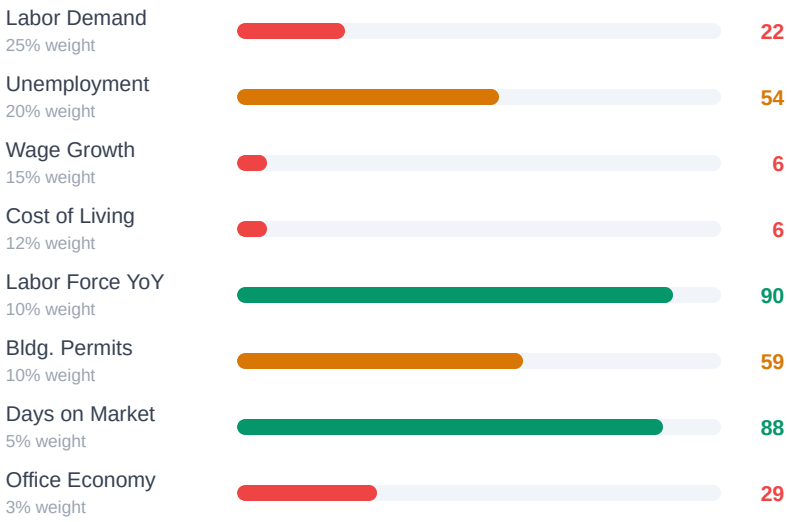
**C**

VERY POOR

38.1th percentile

Rank 39 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT **3.8%** of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY **+0.5%** avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.2%** nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY **+1.6%** civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS **+13.5%** residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET **37 days** median, +12.1% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**WEAK**

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 38.1th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its low labor demand and stagnant wage growth, which are 22nd percentile and 6th percentile, respectively. The labor demand composite score of 3.95, resulting from -0.25% employment growth YoY and -1.588% weekly hours deviation from trend, signals a contraction in labor demand. These metrics define the city's current economic character, marked by a lack of job expansion and decreased working hours.

### Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of -0.25% YoY and weekly hours deviation of -1.588% from trend indicate a contraction in labor demand, suggesting that the city is experiencing a period of job losses and reduced working hours. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, implying that businesses may face challenges in finding skilled workers due to a shrinking labor market. The negative labor demand composite score reinforces this notion, pointing to a difficult hiring environment.

### Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.80% places the city near the median, ranking 54th percentile, indicating a relatively balanced labor market with neither significant tightness nor slack. This rate suggests that while it may not be overly challenging to hire workers, the market does not have an abundance of available labor, which could lead to moderate wage pressure. For businesses trying to hire, this means they will need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent.

### Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +0.52% is in the bottom tier, ranking 6th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth environment means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also signifies weak bargaining power for workers, potentially impacting their purchasing power. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but workers may have limited disposable income.

### Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $228/sqft to $35.76/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.38, and a percentile rank of 6th, the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The PSF has increased by 2.2% YoY, further reducing affordability. This expense, combined with the low affordability ranking, suggests that the city may struggle to attract talent without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

### Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force has grown by +1.57% YoY, ranking 90th percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate implies that the city has a structural advantage in terms of hiring capacity, as the labor pool is increasing. Businesses looking to expand or relocate may find this growth beneficial for their hiring needs.

**Building Permits**

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +13.52%, ranking 59th percentile, suggesting that housing supply is expanding. This increase in permits signals developer confidence and a future expansion in housing supply, which could improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. However, the moderate rank indicates that this expansion is not exceptionally strong compared to other metros.

**Days on Market**

The current median days on market is 37 days, with a YoY increase of 12.1%, ranking 88th percentile. This indicates a slower market where homes are sitting longer before being sold. For workers relocating to this city, the slower market could make it easier to find and purchase a home, as there is less competition and pressure to act quickly.

**Office Economy**

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors is ranked 29th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these areas. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more appropriate for industries with different skill requirements.

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area offers businesses a unique combination of an expanding labor force and a slower housing market, which could facilitate relocation and talent attraction. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's low labor demand and stagnant wage growth, which may signal underlying economic challenges and impact the ability to find and retain skilled workers.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #40 OF 50

# Denver

Denver-Aurora-Centennial

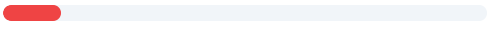
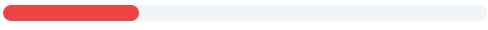
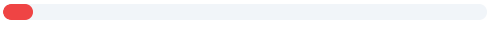
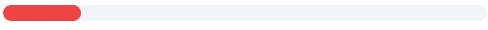
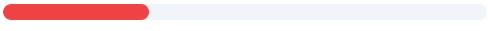
**C-**

CRITICAL

36.6th percentile

Rank 40 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Labor Demand (25% weight) |  | 68 |
| Unemployment (20% weight) |  | 12 |
| Wage Growth (15% weight) |  | 28 |
| Cost of Living (12% weight) |  | 60 |
| Labor Force YoY (10% weight) |  | 6 |
| Bldg. Permits (10% weight) |  | 16 |
| Days on Market (5% weight) |  | 30 |
| Office Economy (3% weight) |  | 67 |

## KEY INDICATORS

**UNEMPLOYMENT**
4.6%
of civilian labor force

**WAGE GROWTH YOY**
+2.1%
avg hourly earnings

**EMPLOYMENT GROWTH**
+0.1%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

**LABOR FORCE YOY**
-3.0%
civilian labor force growth

**BUILDING PERMITS**
-19.6%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

**DAYS ON MARKET**
58 days
median, -3.3% YoY

**LABOR MARKET SIGNAL**

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 36.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, with a composite score in the 68th percentile, and its high unemployment rate, which stands at 4.60% and ranks in the 12th percentile. These two metrics suggest a complex labor market with both positive and negative trends.

### Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is +0.10% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating +1.564% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth, indicating that the labor market is experiencing an increase in workload without relying on survivor squeeze. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to expand or establish operations in the area.

### Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 4.60%, ranking in the 12th percentile, which indicates a relatively loose labor market with some slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may have an easier time finding candidates, but may also face weaker local consumer demand due to the higher unemployment rate. As a result, companies may need to consider the potential impact on their customer base and revenue streams.

### Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is +2.15%, which ranks in the 28th percentile and indicates moderate wage growth. This means that employer labor costs are rising, but at a slower pace than in many other cities, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not as quickly as in other areas. As a result, businesses may need to balance their labor costs with the need to attract and retain top talent in a competitive market.

### Cost of Living

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a cost of living score in the 60th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $279/sqft to $43.51/hr, or 6.41. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, with a falling PSF value (-3.1% YoY) contributing to its high affordability score. This makes it an attractive location for talent, as workers can afford a higher quality of life without requiring significant wage premiums.

### Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is shrinking at a rate of -2.99% year-over-year, which ranks in the 6th percentile and indicates a contracting labor pool. This is a significant structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may struggle to find qualified candidates in a shrinking labor market. As a result, companies may need to consider investing in training and development programs to attract and retain top talent.

**Building Permits**

The number of residential building permits in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is declining at a rate of -19.62% year-over-year, which ranks in the 16th percentile and indicates a tightening housing supply. This signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as a lack of new housing developments could drive up prices and make it harder for workers to relocate to the area.

**Days on Market**

The median days on market for homes in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is currently 58 days, with a year-over-year decline of -3.3%. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, although the decline in days on market is slowing. For workers relocating to this city, the market is still relatively competitive, but the slowing pace of sales may make it slightly more accessible for buyers.

**Office Economy**

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking in the 67th percentile. This makes it an attractive location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. However, it may be less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area offers businesses a complex labor market with both opportunities and challenges, including a relatively affordable cost of living and a deep professional talent pool. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force, which could make it difficult for companies to find and retain qualified candidates, and may require significant investments in training and development programs to attract and retain top talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #41 OF 50

# Riverside

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario

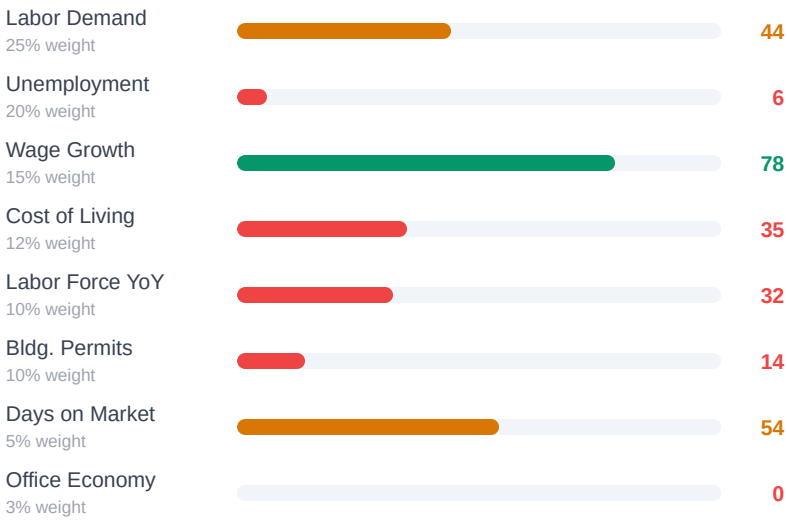
**C-**

CRITICAL

35.5th percentile

Rank 41 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT **5.9%** of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY **+5.5%** avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.8%** nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY **-1.7%** civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS **-20.0%** residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET **64 days** median, -4.5% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**GROWING**

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it at the 35.5th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth rate of 5.51% year-over-year and its low unemployment rate of 5.90%, which signals a tight labor market. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging hiring environment for businesses.

### Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 0.75% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.149% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a moderate labor demand expansion, as the job market is growing, but hours worked are slightly below trend. This suggests that while there is some genuine demand for labor, it is not as strong as it could be.

### Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 5.90%, ranking it at the 6th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses may face significant challenges in hiring, as there are fewer available workers, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. The tight market also implies upward pressure on wages.

### Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 5.51%, ranking it at the 78th percentile, indicating fast wage growth. This rapid wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs, but can also expect a more affluent local consumer base.

### Cost of Living

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario has a cost of living score ranking it at the 35th percentile, with a PSF of $330/sqft and average hourly earnings of $35.45, resulting in a ratio of 9.31. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive, which may make it harder to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling -1.5% year-over-year is a positive sign, but the city still has a ways to go in terms of affordability.

### Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is shrinking at a rate of -1.74% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor pool. This implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of available workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to be more aggressive in their recruitment efforts or consider alternative locations with more abundant labor supplies.

### Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is falling -19.99% year-over-year, indicating a tightening housing supply. This signals a potential future affordability crisis and workforce accommodation challenges, as the supply of housing is not keeping pace with demand. This could further exacerbate the tight labor market and drive up wages.

**Days on Market**

The median days on market for homes in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 64 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -4.5%. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the decrease in days on market suggests some normalization in the market, which could make it slightly more accessible for workers.

**Office Economy**

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario has a very shallow professional talent pool, ranking at the 0th percentile in terms of office economy share. This makes it a less suitable location for businesses in the tech, finance, or consulting sectors, which rely on a deep pool of specialized knowledge workers. However, it may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area offers businesses a unique combination of high wage growth and a tight labor market, but also poses significant challenges in terms of hiring and affordability. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening labor market and potential future affordability crisis, which could drive up wages and make it harder to attract and retain talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #42 OF 50

# Richmond

Richmond

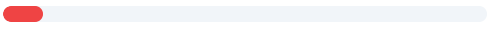
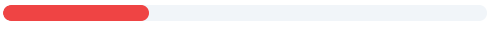
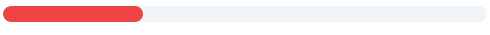
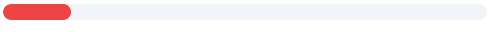
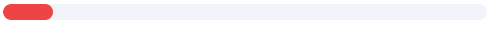
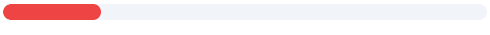
**C-**

CRITICAL

35.3th percentile

Rank 42 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Labor Demand<br>25% weight |  | 8 |
| Unemployment<br>20% weight |  | 66 |
| Wage Growth<br>15% weight |  | 30 |
| Cost of Living<br>12% weight |  | 29 |
| Labor Force YoY<br>10% weight |  | 14 |
| Bldg. Permits<br>10% weight |  | 96 |
| Days on Market<br>5% weight |  | 10 |
| Office Economy<br>3% weight |  | 20 |

## KEY INDICATORS

**UNEMPLOYMENT**
**3.6%**
of civilian labor force

**WAGE GROWTH YOY**
**+2.4%**
avg hourly earnings

**EMPLOYMENT GROWTH**
**-0.8%**
nonfarm payrolls YoY

**LABOR FORCE YOY**
**-2.6%**
civilian labor force growth

**BUILDING PERMITS**
**+83.8%**
residential YoY (3mo avg)

**DAYS ON MARKET**
**44 days**
median, -4.3% YoY

### LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**SQUEEZE**

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Richmond metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 35.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with an employment growth rate of -0.82% and a labor demand composite score of 2.93, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile. Additionally, the city's labor force growth rate of -2.57% YoY also significantly contributes to its economic profile.

**Labor Demand**

The employment growth rate in Richmond is -0.82%, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.219%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, as the city is experiencing job losses while hours are slightly above trend, indicating a potential survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This scenario suggests that the labor market is not expanding.

**Unemployment**

The unemployment rate in Richmond is 3.60%, which ranks in the above-average tier at the 66th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire in this city. As a result, businesses may face some wage pressure when trying to attract and retain talent.

**Wage Growth**

The year-over-year wage growth in Richmond is +2.40%, which is below average, ranking at the 30th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, albeit not rapidly. This could be beneficial for businesses looking to manage labor costs.

**Cost of Living**

Richmond has a cost of living score that ranks in the below-average tier at the 29th percentile, with a PSF of $226/sqft and an average hourly earnings of $35.92/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.29. This means that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is increasing by 0.9% YoY further exacerbates the affordability issue.

**Labor Force Growth**

The labor force in Richmond is contracting at a rate of -2.57% YoY, indicating that the supply of workers is shrinking. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential employees is decreasing, making it more difficult for businesses to find the talent they need.

**Building Permits**

The number of building permits in Richmond has increased by 83.77% YoY, which is in the top tier at the 96th percentile. This significant increase signals that housing supply is expanding, which could lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce in the future.

**Days on Market**

The median days on market in Richmond is 44 days, with a YoY decrease of -4.3%. This relatively fast pace of home sales indicates a competitive market, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing. The decreasing trend suggests that the market is becoming even more competitive.

**Office Economy**

Richmond's professional and office worker share ranks in the below-average tier at the 20th percentile, with a composite score of 1.73. This indicates that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool in professional and office sectors, making it less suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, or HQ decisions that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool.

The Richmond metro area offers a mixed bag for businesses, with some challenges in labor demand, cost of living, and labor force growth. However, the significant increase in building permits could lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce in the future. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the shrinking labor force, which could make it difficult to find and retain talent, potentially hindering business growth and expansion.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #43 OF 50

# Memphis

Memphis

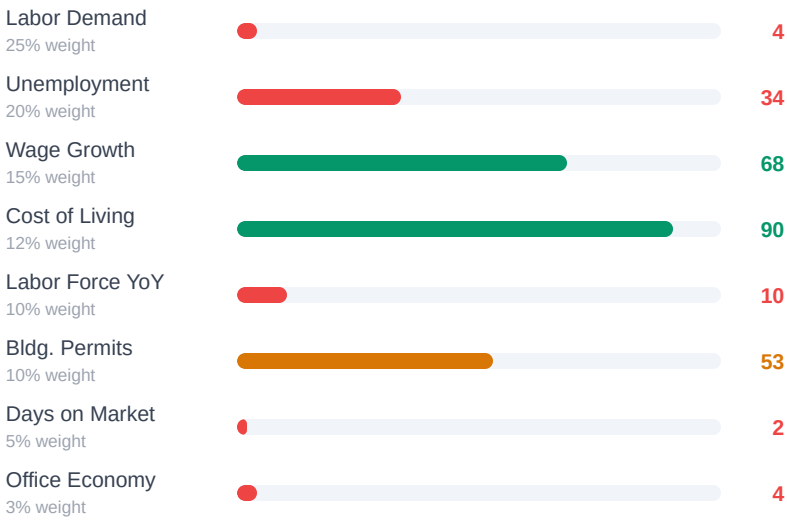
**C-**

CRITICAL

35.3th percentile

Rank 43 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT **4.6%** of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY **+4.5%** avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.5%** nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY **-2.8%** civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS **+5.4%** residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET **72 days** median, +7.5% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**SQUEEZE**

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Memphis has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 35.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a labor demand composite score of 2.11, and its high cost of living affordability, with a ratio of $153/sqft to $33.22/hr, ranking in the top tier at the 90th percentile. These metrics signal a complex economic environment with both challenges and opportunities.

**Labor Demand**

Memphis has an employment growth rate of -0.49% and weekly hours deviation of +1.586% from its own trend, indicating a contraction in labor demand with hours above trend, which suggests a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This combination signals that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 2.11 ranks in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile, further emphasizing the challenges in the labor market.

**Unemployment**

The unemployment rate in Memphis is 4.60%, ranking below average at the 34th percentile, indicating a moderate level of slack in the labor market. This means that while it may not be extremely difficult to hire, there is still some competition for talent. For a business trying to hire in Memphis, this rate suggests that there are available workers, but it may not be as easy to find the right candidates as in cities with higher unemployment rates.

**Wage Growth**

Memphis has a year-over-year wage growth rate of +4.52%, ranking above average at the 68th percentile, indicating relatively fast wage growth. This implies that employer labor costs are rising, and worker purchasing power is increasing. As a result, businesses may face higher labor costs, but workers will have more disposable income to spend in the local economy.

**Cost of Living**

Memphis has a cost of living ratio of $153/sqft to $33.22/hr, with the price per square foot falling by -2.5% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 90th percentile. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The falling price per square foot is a key driver of this affordability, enhancing the city's talent attraction advantage.

**Labor Force Growth**

The civilian labor force in Memphis is contracting at a rate of -2.77% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is shrinking, presenting a structural headwind for hiring and potentially limiting the city's ability to

support business growth.

**Building Permits**

Memphis has a year-over-year change in building permits of +5.41%, ranking near the median at the 53rd percentile. This suggests that housing supply is slowly expanding, which could improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce in the future. However, the moderate pace of expansion may not be enough to keep up with demand, potentially leading to future affordability challenges.

**Days on Market**

The current median days on market in Memphis is 72 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.5%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. This indicates a slower market where homes are sitting longer before being sold, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, this slower pace could also signal weakening demand in the housing market.

**Office Economy**

Memphis has an office economy percentile rank of 4th, indicating a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This makes the city less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but potentially more suitable for industries with different skill requirements, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The city of Memphis offers a complex economic environment with challenges in labor demand and labor force growth, but also opportunities in its affordable cost of living and relatively fast wage growth. The single biggest risk or constraint for a business considering location in Memphis is the shrinking labor force, which could limit the city's ability to support long-term growth and require strategic hiring and talent retention strategies.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #44 OF 50

# Fresno

Fresno

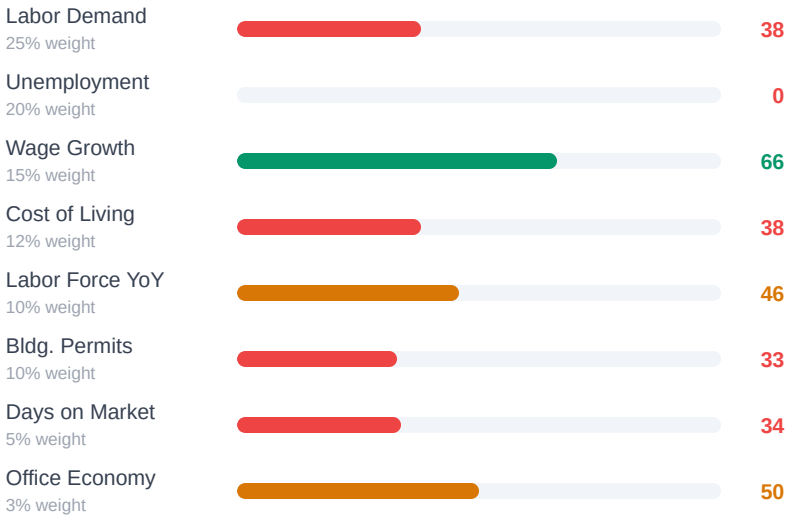
**C-**

CRITICAL

35.0th percentile

Rank 44 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT **7.8%** of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY **+4.5%** avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.8%** nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY **-1.3%** civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS **-6.9%** residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET **58 days** median, -1.7% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**GROWING**

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Fresno has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it at the 35.0th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 7.80% and its above-average wage growth of +4.51% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a complex labor market with both opportunities and challenges for businesses.

### Labor Demand

Fresno's employment growth rate is +0.79% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.503% below trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.90, which ranks below average at the 38th percentile. This combination signals a moderate expansion of jobs, but with hours worked below trend, it may indicate some level of survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This could lead to fatigue and decreased productivity among the workforce.

### Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Fresno is 7.80%, ranking at the 0th percentile, indicating a significant amount of slack in the labor market. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire workers, but the local consumer demand may be weaker due to the high unemployment rate. Companies looking to hire may have an advantage in terms of availability of workers, but may also face challenges in terms of local market demand.

### Wage Growth

Wage growth in Fresno is +4.51% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 66th percentile. This fast wage growth signals rising labor costs for employers, but also good news for worker purchasing power. As wages rise, businesses may need to adjust their pricing strategies or operational efficiencies to maintain profitability, while workers will have more disposable income to spend in the local economy.

### Cost of Living

Fresno's cost of living, with a PSF of $263/sqft and average hourly earnings of $34.06/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.72, ranks below average at the 38th percentile. This means that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is rising by +1.1% year-over-year further exacerbates the affordability issue.

### Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Fresno is shrinking at a rate of -1.30% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 46th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply may pose a structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may face challenges in finding qualified workers to fill open positions. This could lead to increased competition for talent and upward pressure on wages.

**Building Permits**

The number of building permits in Fresno is decreasing by -6.89% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 33rd percentile. This decline in building permits signals a tightening of housing supply, which could lead to decreased affordability and increased costs for workers, making it harder for businesses to attract and retain talent.

**Days on Market**

The median days on market for homes in Fresno is 58 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -1.7%. This relatively fast market, ranking below average at the 34th percentile, means that homes are selling quickly, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. This may require businesses to offer relocation assistance or other incentives to attract talent.

**Office Economy**

Fresno's office economy, with a percentile rank of 50th, has a moderately deep professional talent pool. This makes the city suited for businesses that require a mix of office and non-office workers, but may not be the best fit for companies that require a highly specialized or knowledge-intensive workforce, such as tech or finance firms.

In conclusion, Fresno offers businesses a unique combination of a relatively low-cost labor market and above-average wage growth, but also poses challenges in terms of labor force contraction and decreasing affordability. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for decreased affordability and increased costs for workers, which could make it harder to attract and retain talent, and ultimately impact business profitability.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #45 OF 50

# Indianapolis

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood

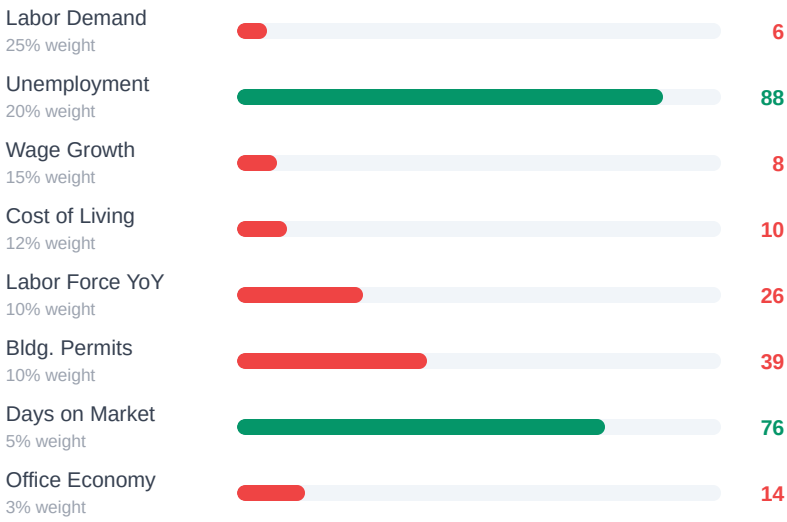
**C-**

CRITICAL

32.3th percentile

Rank 45 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT<br>**3.3%**<br>of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY<br>**+0.6%**<br>avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH<br>**-1.1%**<br>nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY<br>**-1.9%**<br>civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS<br>**-3.4%**<br>residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET<br>**53 days**<br>median, +12.8% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**SQUEEZE**

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 32.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a labor demand composite score of 2.36, ranking in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile, and its tight unemployment market, with an unemployment rate of 3.30%, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

### Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is -1.05% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.471%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, as the city is experiencing job losses while hours are slightly above trend, indicating a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This scenario suggests that businesses may face difficulties in finding the right talent.

### Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 3.30%, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile. This indicates a tight labor market with little slack, making it challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent in this competitive market.

### Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is +0.58%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile. This stagnant wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies weak bargaining power for workers. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but workers may not have strong purchasing power.

### Cost of Living

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood has a cost of living score ranking it in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile, with a PSF of $165/sqft and average hourly earnings of $33.86/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.87. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The PSF has increased by 4.4% year-over-year, further reducing affordability. As a result, businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the city's high cost of living may deter some workers.

### Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is contracting at a rate of -1.87% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 26th percentile. This decline in labor force supply suggests that the city's workforce is shrinking, creating a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion.

**Building Permits**

The number of residential building permits in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood has decreased by -3.35% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 39th percentile. This decline in building permits signals a tightening of the housing supply, which may lead to reduced affordability and increased competition for housing in the future.

**Days on Market**

The median days on market for homes in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 53 days, with a year-over-year increase of 12.8%, ranking above average at the 76th percentile. This suggests a slower market, where homes are taking longer to sell. For workers relocating to this city, this may indicate a more accessible and less competitive housing market.

**Office Economy**

The share of professional and office workers in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is relatively low, ranking in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile. This indicates a shallower talent pool for businesses requiring specialized office or professional skills, making the city less suited for tech, finance, or consulting businesses. However, it may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area offers businesses a tight labor market with low unemployment, but this also means that hiring may be challenging and wages may be under upward pressure. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this city is the low labor demand and shrinking labor force, which may limit the city's ability to support business expansion and growth.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #46 OF 50

# Jacksonville

Jacksonville

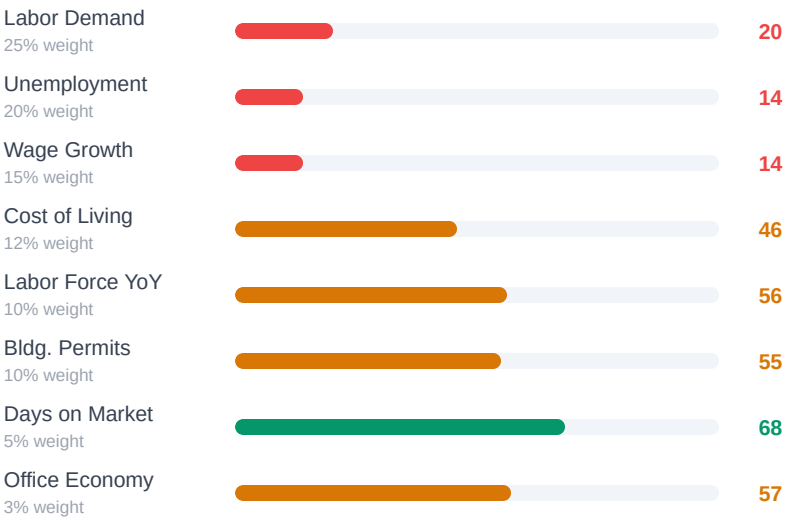
**C-**

CRITICAL

31.6th percentile

Rank 46 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT<br>**4.8%**<br>of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY<br>**+1.3%**<br>avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH<br>**+0.1%**<br>nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY<br>**-0.6%**<br>civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS<br>**+8.2%**<br>residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET<br>**66 days**<br>median, -12.0% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**GROWING**

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Jacksonville has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 31.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 3.86, and its high unemployment rate of 4.80%, which ranks in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

**Labor Demand**

Jacksonville's employment growth rate is a mere 0.06% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.520% from its own 12-month baseline, indicating a lack of genuine demand expansion. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than a survivor squeeze, as hours are not increasing to absorb eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 3.86 is below average, ranking at the 20th percentile.

**Unemployment**

The unemployment rate in Jacksonville is 4.80%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile, indicating a market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it relatively easier to hire workers, but may also face weaker local consumer demand. The unemployment rate suggests that the market is not tight, giving employers some leverage in hiring and wage negotiations.

**Wage Growth**

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Jacksonville is 1.34%, which is relatively slow and ranks in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile. This stagnant wage growth implies that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing significantly. The slow wage growth may attract businesses looking for a flat cost environment, but it also indicates weak bargaining power for workers.

**Cost of Living**

Jacksonville has a cost of living ratio of $213/sqft to $37.45/hr, with a PSF falling -1.4% year-over-year, resulting in a near-median affordability score ranking at the 46th percentile. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The falling PSF is a key driver of this affordability, making it easier for businesses to attract and retain workers.

**Labor Force Growth**

The civilian labor force in Jacksonville is contracting at a rate of -0.56% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of workers is decreasing. Businesses may face challenges in finding qualified

workers, and may need to invest in training or recruitment programs to attract talent.

**Building Permits**

The number of residential building permits in Jacksonville is increasing by 8.24% year-over-year, indicating an expansion of housing supply. This growth in permits suggests that developer confidence is rising, and future housing supply is likely to increase, improving affordability and workforce accommodation. The increasing permits are a positive sign for businesses looking to relocate or expand, as it indicates a growing and more affordable housing market.

**Days on Market**

The median days on market in Jacksonville is 66 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -12.0%, resulting in an above-average ranking at the 68th percentile. This means that homes are selling relatively quickly, making it a competitive market for workers relocating to the city. However, the decreasing days on market also suggests a hot market, which may make it challenging for workers to find affordable housing.

**Office Economy**

Jacksonville's professional and office worker share is 2.76, ranking near the median at the 57th percentile, indicating a moderate depth of talent pool. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a highly specialized or deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics-dominant companies. However, it may not be the best fit for tech, finance, or consulting businesses that require a highly skilled and specialized workforce.

The city of Jacksonville offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a slowing housing market, but its low labor demand and high unemployment rate pose significant challenges. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor pool, which may limit the city's ability to support business growth and expansion. Despite these challenges, Jacksonville's growing housing supply and moderate talent pool make it an attractive location for certain types of businesses.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #47 OF 50

# Grand Rapids

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood

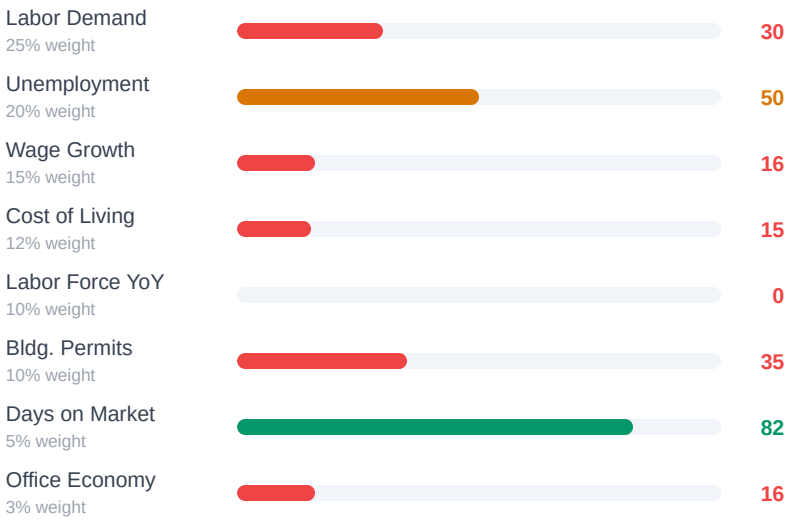
**D**

EMERGENCY

29.7th percentile

Rank 47 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT<br>**4.2%**<br>of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY<br>**+1.4%**<br>avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH<br>**+0.7%**<br>nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY<br>**-7.2%**<br>civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS<br>**-5.7%**<br>residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET<br>**42 days**<br>median, +7.7% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**GROWING**

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area has an overall grade of D, ranking 29.7th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its low labor demand and stagnant wage growth. The city's labor demand composite score of 4.59, combining a +0.68% employment growth rate and a -0.658% weekly hours deviation from trend, signals a contraction in genuine demand expansion. This, coupled with a wage growth rate of +1.41%, which ranks in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile, defines the city's current economic character.

### Labor Demand

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area has an employment growth rate of +0.68% and a weekly hours deviation of -0.658% from its own trend, indicating a lack of genuine demand expansion. This combination suggests that while there is some job growth, the hours worked are below the city's own trend, which may signal a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 4.59 is below average, ranking at the 30th percentile.

### Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 4.20%, which is near the median, ranking at the 50th percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced market with neither significant slack nor tightness. For a business trying to hire in this city, the implication is that while it may not be overly difficult to find talent, there is also not a large pool of unemployed workers to draw from, suggesting moderate hiring conditions.

### Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is +1.41%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile. This stagnant wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power. For businesses, this could mean a relatively flat cost environment, but it may also indicate a less attractive market for top talent seeking better compensation.

### Cost of Living

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood has a cost of living score that ranks in the bottom tier at the 15th percentile, with a PSF of $215/sqft and an average hourly earnings of $32.58/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.60. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, especially since the PSF is rising at a rate of +1.9% YoY. The high cost of living means that the city may struggle to attract talent without offering wage premiums, making it less competitive in the labor market.

### Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is contracting at a rate of -7.20% year-over-year, ranking at the bottom tier (0th percentile). This significant decline in the labor force supply implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is shrinking. Businesses looking to expand or establish operations in this city may face challenges in finding the necessary talent due to this contraction.

**Building Permits**

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is -5.72%, indicating a tightening in housing supply. This decline suggests that developer confidence may be waning, and the future housing supply is not expanding as rapidly as needed, which could lead to affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

**Days on Market**

The current median days on market for homes in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 42 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.7%, ranking in the top tier at the 82nd percentile. This slower market means that homes are sitting longer before being sold, which could be beneficial for workers relocating to the city as it indicates a more accessible and less competitive housing market.

**Office Economy**

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is relatively low, ranking in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile. This suggests that the city's talent pool is not as deep in professional and office skills, making it less suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, or HQ sectors that require a high concentration of such talent. However, it may be more suitable for industries with different skill requirements.

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area offers a business environment with moderate unemployment and relatively flat labor costs, but it is constrained by low labor demand, stagnant wage growth, and a shrinking labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker considering this location is the significant decline in the labor force, which poses a structural challenge for hiring and talent acquisition, potentially limiting the city's attractiveness for businesses reliant on a growing and skilled workforce.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #48 OF 50

# Louisville

Louisville-Jefferson County

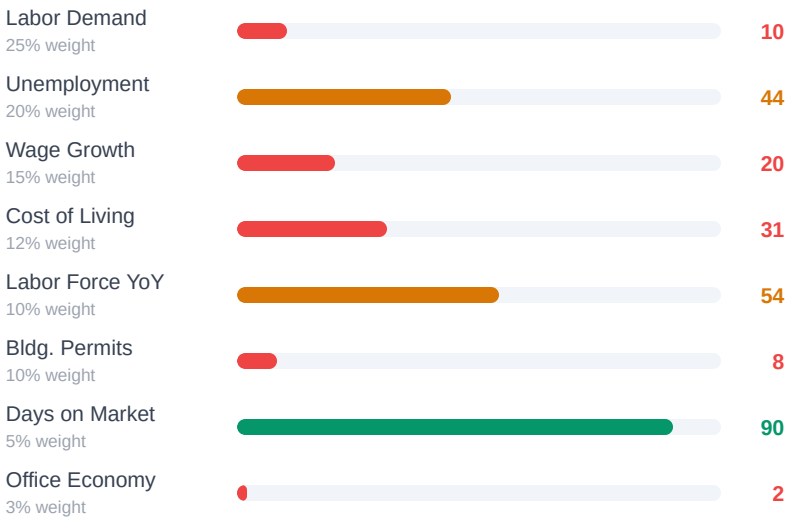
**D**

EMERGENCY

28.8th percentile

Rank 48 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT<br>**4.1%**<br>of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY<br>**+1.7%**<br>avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH<br>**-0.1%**<br>nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY<br>**-0.8%**<br>civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS<br>**-31.1%**<br>residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET<br>**45 days**<br>median, +12.5% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**SQUEEZE**

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area has an overall grade of D, ranking 28.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score largely defined by its weak labor demand and stagnant office economy. The labor demand composite score of 2.98, combining a -0.13% employment growth rate and a +1.140% weekly hours deviation, signals a contraction in job market activity. This is further exacerbated by a low office/professional worker share, which significantly impacts the city's economic character.

### Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is -0.13% year-over-year, coupled with a +1.140% deviation in weekly hours from its own 12-month baseline, indicating a contraction in labor demand rather than genuine demand expansion. This combination suggests that while hours are slightly above trend, the overall job market is not adding positions, potentially leading to a survivor squeeze where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score ranks in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile.

### Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Louisville-Jefferson County stands at 4.10%, placing it near the median at the 44th percentile. This rate indicates a labor market with some slack, rather than being extremely tight, which means businesses may find it somewhat easier to hire compared to cities with lower unemployment rates. However, this also implies that local consumer demand might not be as strong as in areas with lower unemployment.

### Wage Growth

Wage growth in the area is +1.74% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 20th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but not at a rapid pace, which can be beneficial for worker purchasing power without overly pressuring business budgets. The wage growth rate is not stagnant but is also not fast enough to significantly drive up labor costs.

### Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $178/sqft to $31.41/hr, Louisville-Jefferson County ranks below average in terms of affordability at the 31st percentile. This means the city is not particularly affordable relative to its peers, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that the PSF is not falling year-over-year further suggests that affordability is not improving.

### Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Louisville-Jefferson County is shrinking at a rate of -0.83% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 54th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply indicates a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is decreasing.

Businesses looking to expand or establish operations here may face challenges in finding the necessary talent.

**Building Permits**

Residential building permits have decreased by -31.05% year-over-year, placing the city in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile. This sharp decline signals a tightening in future housing supply, which could lead to decreased affordability and make it more difficult for the workforce to find accommodation, potentially affecting the city's attractiveness to relocating workers and businesses.

**Days on Market**

Homes in Louisville-Jefferson County are currently sitting on the market for 45 days, with a year-over-year increase of +12.5%, ranking in the top tier at the 90th percentile. This slower market means that homes are taking longer to sell, which can be beneficial for buyers or relocating workers, indicating a more accessible and less competitive housing market.

**Office Economy**

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors is 0.29, ranking in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. This indicates a shallow talent pool in professional and office sectors, making the city less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, consulting, or HQ operations. Instead, the economy may be more industrial or logistics-dominant.

The bottom line for businesses considering Louisville-Jefferson County is that while it may offer some advantages in terms of a slightly slower housing market, the overall economic indicators, particularly the weak labor demand and lack of professional talent, pose significant risks. The single biggest constraint a decision-maker should factor in is the challenging labor market conditions, which could hinder both hiring and business growth.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #49 OF 50

# Chicago

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin

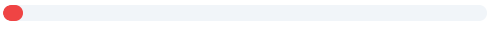
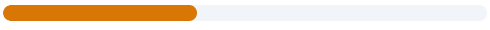
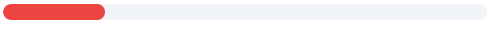
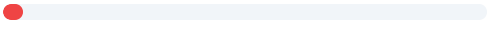
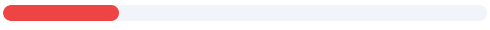
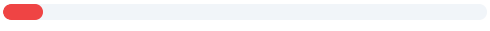
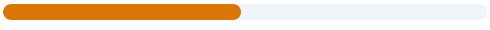
**D**

EMERGENCY

26.5th percentile

Rank 49 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Labor Demand (25% weight) |  | 50 |
| Unemployment (20% weight) |  | 4 |
| Wage Growth (15% weight) |  | 40 |
| Cost of Living (12% weight) |  | 21 |
| Labor Force YoY (10% weight) |  | 4 |
| Bldg. Permits (10% weight) |  | 24 |
| Days on Market (5% weight) |  | 8 |
| Office Economy (3% weight) |  | 49 |

## KEY INDICATORS

**UNEMPLOYMENT**
5.2%
of civilian labor force

**WAGE GROWTH YOY**
+3.3%
avg hourly earnings

**EMPLOYMENT GROWTH**
+0.2%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

**LABOR FORCE YOY**
-3.1%
civilian labor force growth

**BUILDING PERMITS**
-15.2%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

**DAYS ON MARKET**
36 days
median, -5.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**STRONG**

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area has an overall grade of D, ranking in the 26.5th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 5.43. This city's economic character is most defined by its high unemployment rate of 5.20% and its negative labor force growth rate of -3.13% YoY, indicating significant challenges in the job market. The combination of these metrics suggests a struggling economy with limited job opportunities.

**Labor Demand**

The employment growth rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +0.22% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating +0.823% from the city's own 12-month baseline, resulting in a near-median labor demand composite score. This combination signals a modest expansion of genuine demand, but the low overall growth rate and high unemployment rate temper this signal. The labor market is not experiencing a strong surge in demand.

**Unemployment**

The unemployment rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 5.20%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile, indicating a significant amount of slack in the labor market. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire workers, but the local consumer demand may be weaker due to the high unemployment rate. Companies looking to hire may have an advantage in terms of available talent, but may also face challenges in terms of local market demand.

**Wage Growth**

The year-over-year wage growth in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +3.28%, ranking near the median at the 40th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a moderate pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing. However, the wage growth is not strong enough to drive significant economic expansion.

**Cost of Living**

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has a cost of living score ranking in the 21st percentile, with a PSF of $220/sqft and average hourly earnings of $37.65/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.84. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive, which may make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The city's affordability is below average, which could be a disadvantage for businesses looking to relocate or expand.

**Labor Force Growth**

The labor force in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is contracting at a rate of -3.13% YoY, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction signals a structural headwind for hiring, making it challenging for businesses to find the talent they need. The declining labor force growth rate is a

significant concern for companies looking to expand or establish operations in the area.

**Building Permits**

The number of building permits in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has decreased by -15.18% YoY, indicating a tightening of the housing supply. This decrease signals a potential supply squeeze in the future, which could lead to decreased affordability and make it more challenging for the workforce to find accommodation. The decline in building permits is a concern for businesses that rely on a growing and accessible workforce.

**Days on Market**

The median days on market in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 36 days, with a YoY decrease of -5.3%, indicating a relatively fast-paced market. However, the low percentile rank of 8th percentile suggests that homes are still selling quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The fast-paced market may make it difficult for businesses to attract talent from other areas.

**Office Economy**

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has an office economy score ranking in the 49th percentile, indicating a deep professional talent pool. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-dominant economies. The city's strong office economy is a significant advantage for businesses that rely on specialized professional talent.

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area offers businesses a relatively low-cost labor market with moderate wage growth, but the high unemployment rate and shrinking labor force pose significant challenges. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the limited job market and declining labor force growth, which may make it difficult to find and retain talent in the area.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #50 OF 50

# Detroit

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn

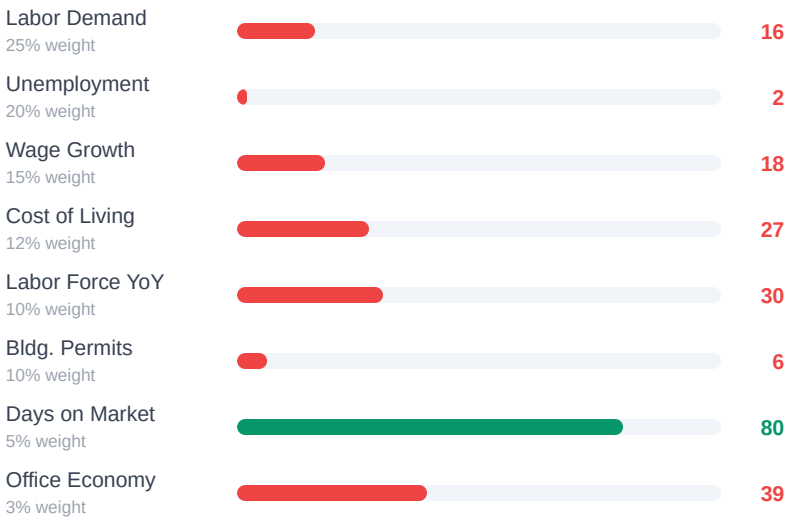
**D**

EMERGENCY

19.1th percentile

Rank 50 of 50 metros

## METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)




## KEY INDICATORS

| | |
|---|---|
| UNEMPLOYMENT **5.7%** of civilian labor force | WAGE GROWTH YOY **+1.5%** avg hourly earnings |
| EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.2%** nonfarm payrolls YoY | LABOR FORCE YOY **-1.8%** civilian labor force growth |
| BUILDING PERMITS **-33.0%** residential YoY (3mo avg) | DAYS ON MARKET **43 days** median, +7.5% YoY |

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

**SQUEEZE**

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

## ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area has an overall grade of D, ranking in the 19.1th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 3.58. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 5.70% and its negative employment growth rate of -0.20%. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging labor market for businesses looking to hire.

### Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is -0.20% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating 0.439% above the city's own 12-month trend. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. This metric ranks in the bottom tier, at the 16th percentile.

### Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 5.70%, which is relatively high, ranking in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. This indicates a labor market with some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire, but also suggesting weaker local consumer demand. Businesses looking to hire in this market may find it easier to staff, but may also face less competitive pressure to offer high wages.

### Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is +1.48%, which is relatively slow, ranking in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile. This slow wage growth suggests a flat cost environment for employers, but also weak bargaining power for workers. As a result, businesses may not face significant labor cost pressures, but workers may not have strong purchasing power.

### Cost of Living

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn has a cost of living score that ranks in the 27th percentile, with a PSF of $186/sqft and average hourly earnings of $37.53/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.96. This suggests that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, although the PSF is rising 3.3% year-over-year. This affordability could be a talent attraction advantage for businesses, as they may not need to offer wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

### Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is contracting at a rate of -1.76% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 30th percentile. This decline in labor force supply suggests a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find and recruit talent. As a result, businesses may need to invest more in recruitment and training to attract and retain workers.

### Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is declining at a rate of -32.95% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile. This sharp decline in building permits suggests a tightening housing supply, which could lead to decreased affordability and make it more challenging for workers to relocate to the city. This could be a significant risk for businesses looking to attract talent to the area.

**Days on Market**

The median days on market for homes in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 43 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.5%, ranking in the top tier at the 80th percentile. This suggests a slower market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, this could also indicate a weakening demand for housing, which could have implications for the local economy.

**Office Economy**

The share of professional and office workers in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 2.24, ranking below average at the 39th percentile. This suggests a relatively shallow talent pool for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, making it less suitable for HQ decisions or businesses requiring specialized knowledge-economy talent. However, the city may be more suited for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a slower housing market, making it more accessible for relocating workers. However, the city's low unemployment rate, slow wage growth, and declining labor force supply suggest a challenging labor market, and the sharp decline in building permits poses a significant risk to future affordability and workforce accommodation.